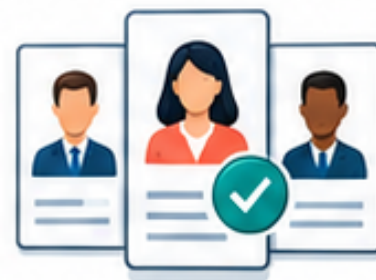


HIRING / PERFORMANCE / EMPLOYEE RELATIONS / CHANGE

Human Resources English

Be clear about expectations. Be careful with people.



Phil Stilwell

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Eight lessons. Eleven extended conversations.

INSIDE THE BOOK

192 vocabulary entries / 128 reusable phrases
220 extended-dialogue turns / 11 transfer exchanges
Word banks and explained answer keys

Upper-intermediate to advanced (B2-C1). For HR partners, recruiters, people managers, and employee-relations teams.

2026 edition

Eight scenarios. Eight skills.

Eight people-management conversations connecting fair questions, clear expectations, and accurate records.

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Clear language is part of fair treatment.

Human resources conversations often carry two responsibilities at once: responding to a person and keeping the record accurate. A concern is not yet a finding. A salary midpoint is not an individual promise. A manager can acknowledge uncertainty without sounding indifferent. These fictional cases practice the words that make those distinctions understandable while keeping next steps specific.

Describe the work, not a personality

Replace vague judgments with a task, an observable behavior, and the relevant expectation. Ask for the missing context before assigning a motive.

"The last two reports omitted the summary; I have not established why."

Name the status of the information

Distinguish what someone reported, what a document shows, what has been verified, and what the authorized process has decided. Each supports a different statement.

"The note records an allegation, not a finding."

Make a limited promise useful

Commit to the next contact or review you can deliver. Do not replace uncertainty with an unsupported outcome, secrecy guarantee, or employment assurance.

"I will update you on Friday even if the review remains open."

Use the actual policy and jurisdiction

These exercises supply fictional policy terms where needed. Real eligibility, process, privacy, representation, and employment obligations depend on the relevant facts and applicable rules.

"That is the policy range; your individual placement requires a separate explanation."

PROFESSIONAL BOUNDARIES

Original fictional language practice, not legal, employment, benefits, medical, or investigation advice. People, policies, figures, and outcomes are invented. Real decisions require current local law, applicable agreements, authorized procedures, and qualified advice. US and UK sources provide identified background, not a universal HR procedure.

What does good fit actually mean?

A Read the situation

Turn vague hiring preferences into observable, job-related criteria and a consistent candidate conversation.

Recruiter Lina and hiring manager Marcus are preparing interviews for a client-operations coordinator. Marcus asks for good cultural fit but has not defined it. The role requires timely client follow-up and escalation of conflicting deadlines. The draft scorecard rewards confidence and shared interests without describing evidence. No applicant has been scored. Lina must clarify the competencies, interview questions, rating basis, and candidate updates before the panel starts making comparisons.

PEOPLE / Lina: Recruiter | Marcus: Hiring manager

TRANSLATE AN IMPRESSION INTO EVIDENCE

A fluent, sociable applicant can create a strong first impression without demonstrating the required work. Ask what the person needs to do, what evidence would demonstrate it, and how every applicant will have a fair opportunity to provide that evidence.

Briefing checks

Circle one answer in each item. Use the briefing.

1. Which tasks are actually required?

A Agreeing with every panel member

B Client follow-up and escalation of conflicting deadlines

C Sharing the manager's hobbies

D Speaking at the fastest pace

2. What is wrong with the draft scorecard?

A It uses impressions without observable evidence criteria.

B It already contains all completed candidate scores.

C It prohibits asking about previous work.

D It measures only the two specified competencies.

3. What is the current selection status?

A The preferred applicant has been selected.

B Every candidate has failed the interview.

C An offer has been accepted.

D No applicant has been scored.

[Answers and explanations: page 85.](#)

The vocabulary that does the work

B Find the words / 1 of 2

Read the definitions and say the common word combinations aloud.

job requisition

An internal request to fill an approved or proposed position.

IN USE open a job requisition

role profile

A description of a position's purpose and required work.

IN USE clarify the role profile

essential criterion

A requirement necessary for the particular role.

IN USE define essential criteria

desirable criterion

A useful attribute that is not a minimum requirement.

IN USE distinguish desirable criteria

job-related competency

A demonstrable capability connected to the work.

IN USE assess job-related competencies

behavioral evidence

Specific actions showing how someone handled a situation.

IN USE request behavioral evidence

structured interview

An interview using consistent questions and evaluation standards.

IN USE conduct a structured interview

behavioral question

A question asking about an actual past action or experience.

IN USE ask a behavioral question

situational question

A question asking how someone would address a supplied scenario.

IN USE use a situational question

scoring rubric

Stated standards used to assign assessment ratings.

IN USE apply the scoring rubric

rating anchor

A description illustrating a particular score level.

IN USE define rating anchors

interview panel

The group responsible for interviewing or assessing candidates.

IN USE brief the interview panel

Precision check

Good cultural fit is too vague to score consistently. Define the actual behavior: following up on commitments and raising deadline conflicts. A shared interest, accent, or outgoing manner does not itself establish either competency.

The vocabulary that does the work

B Find the words / 2 of 2

Read the definitions and say the common word combinations aloud.

candidate pipeline

Applicants at different stages of the recruitment process.

IN USE review the candidate pipeline

screening call

An initial conversation checking relevant requirements and interest.

IN USE arrange a screening call

shortlist

Candidates selected for a further assessment stage.

IN USE develop a shortlist

selection rationale

The evidence-based explanation for a selection decision.

IN USE document the selection rationale

affinity bias

Favoring someone because of perceived similarity to oneself.

IN USE challenge affinity bias

halo effect

Allowing one favorable impression to dominate unrelated judgments.

IN USE check for the halo effect

calibration

Aligning assessors' use of the stated rating standards.

IN USE hold a calibration discussion

work sample

A job-related task used to observe relevant performance.

IN USE evaluate a work sample

candidate experience

How applicants experience the recruitment process and communication.

IN USE improve the candidate experience

reasonable adjustment

A change intended to reduce a relevant barrier, under applicable rules.

IN USE discuss a reasonable adjustment

offer approval

Internal authorization for the terms of a proposed job offer.

IN USE obtain offer approval

time to fill

Elapsed time between defined vacancy and hiring milestones.

IN USE state the time-to-fill basis

Precision check

Consistent questions and common criteria support comparison; identical treatment does not mean ignoring legitimate access needs. Follow the applicable adjustment process. A recruitment metric also needs defined start and end events before its duration is comparable.

Phrases you can actually use

C Notice the language / 1 of 2

CLARIFY THE PREFERENCE

"What specific work behavior do you mean by good fit?"

SEPARATE THE CRITERIA

"Which requirements are essential and which are desirable?"

FOLLOW THE ACTION

"What did you do, and what happened next?"

DEFINE A RATING

"What would distinguish a strong answer from an adequate one?"

RETURN TO THE ROLE

"The role requires client follow-up and timely escalation."

ASK FOR EVIDENCE

"Tell us about a time you handled two conflicting deadlines."

AVOID SOCIAL SCORING

"Shared hobbies are not evidence of this competency."

KEEP COMPARISON CONSISTENT

"Use the same core questions and rating standards."

Fit

Ask fit for which task and on what evidence.

Confident

Describes presentation, not necessarily competence.

Essential

A genuine minimum requirement, not merely a preference.

Phrases you can actually use

C Notice the language / 2 of 2

CHALLENGE AN IMPRESSION

"Confidence alone does not tell us whether the commitments were met."

KEEP ACCESS OPEN

"Explain the assessment and the route for requesting an adjustment."

SEPARATE STAGES

"A shortlist decision is not an approved offer."

AVOID AN INVENTED PROMISE

"We have not made a selection decision yet."

CALIBRATE THE PANEL

"Let us compare the evidence against the agreed anchors."

RECORD THE RATIONALE

"Link the score to the candidate's actual example."

RESPECT THE CANDIDATE

"Tell applicants when they can expect the next update."

CLOSE THE PREPARATION

"Confirm the criteria before the panel starts scoring."

Consistent

Common assessment standards with appropriate access arrangements.

Selected

Identify the stage; shortlisted and hired are different.

Fast

A shorter process does not prove a better selection decision.

Choose the precise message

D Check your understanding

Circle one best answer for each item. Use the stated purpose and case facts, not the option that merely sounds most polite.

1. Which question best elicits behavioral evidence for the required escalation skill?

- A** How many clients did your last employer have in total?
- B** Tell us about a deadline conflict, what you escalated, and the result.
- C** How would you hypothetically handle a deadline conflict tomorrow?
- D** Would your colleagues describe you as confident under pressure?

2. A panelist says, "I liked their energy, so I scored follow-up highly." What is the best response?

- A** Good energy proves every competency.
- B** Replace the score with the panelist's favorite number.
- C** Ignore all evidence because interviews are subjective.
- D** Which example shows how they followed through on a client commitment?

3. What belongs in a selection rationale?

- A** The assumption that fluency guarantees reliability
- B** Relevant evidence linked to the agreed criteria
- C** A guess about the candidate's private life
- D** A record of shared hobbies as proof of competence

4. Which candidate update is supported before selection?

- A** All offer terms are approved.
- B** No further communication is needed.
- C** We are completing interviews and will update you on the stated date.
- D** You have the job because the interview felt positive.

Answers and explanations: [page 85](#).

What does good fit actually mean?

E Conversations / turns 1-10

Complete the numbered gaps. Use each bank entry once, without changing its form. Cover the answers at the end until you finish.

WORD + PHRASE BANK

job-related competency / candidate experience / scoring rubric / Offer approval / rating anchors / selection rationale / affinity bias / behavioral question / structured interview / role profile

- 01 **Marcus:** I want someone who will fit the team. The current draft says confident, approachable, and easy to work with, which sounds reasonable to me.
- 02 **Lina:** Those impressions need a ¹ _____. For this coordinator, the actual requirements are client follow-up and escalation when deadlines conflict.
- 03 **Marcus:** Then let us replace confident with something we can assess. What would show that a candidate follows up with clients and raises a deadline problem early?
- 04 **Lina:** Exactly. Let us start with the ² _____ and describe the actions we need. Then the panel can look for evidence rather than a familiar personality.
- 05 **Marcus:** Could we ask candidates to describe a time when two clients needed something at once? I would want to hear how they handled the competing commitments.
- 06 **Lina:** That is a useful ³ _____. Follow it with what they did, who they contacted, and the result, using the same core prompts across candidates.
- 07 **Marcus:** Can we agree on the scoring before the first interview? I do not want us changing the standard because the opening candidate gives a polished answer.
- 08 **Lina:** We need a ⁴ _____ with clear evidence levels. Strong delivery should not compensate for an example that never explains how the deadline conflict was handled.
- 09 **Marcus:** One panelist likes people who share the team's interests. I understand the impulse, but that does not show whether someone can manage client commitments.
- 10 **Lina:** That is where ⁵ _____ can enter. Bring the discussion back to the required work without turning the panel review into an argument about who seems friendly.

The conversation, continued

E Conversations / turns 11-20

Continue with the word bank on page 10.

- 11 **Marcus:** After each interview, should we compare scores immediately? I want disagreements about evidence to surface before the final shortlist discussion.
- 12 **Lina:** Use the agreed ⁶ _____ when comparing judgments. Ask which part of the example supports the score, not merely whether everyone liked the candidate.
- 13 **Marcus:** Some candidates will have questions about the assessment format. We should explain it early enough for them to raise any access needs.
- 14 **Lina:** Yes. A ⁷ _____ does not mean refusing an appropriate adjustment. Explain the process and route requests through the relevant procedure without making assumptions about the person.
- 15 **Marcus:** We also need to tell candidates when they will hear from us. A long silence can make a well-organized interview feel careless.
- 16 **Lina:** That affects the ⁸ _____. Set a realistic update date and keep it even if the decision is still pending; an update need not be an offer.
- 17 **Marcus:** For the final discussion, I want notes showing why someone progressed. "Good fit" on its own will not help us explain the comparison later.
- 18 **Lina:** Record the ⁹ _____ against the criteria. Distinguish the candidate's actual example from our interpretation, and do not add details they never supplied.
- 19 **Marcus:** Agreed. We will revise the criteria, brief the panel, and complete the interviews. No one should imply an offer is ready merely because a candidate was shortlisted.
- 20 **Lina:** Correct. ¹⁰ _____ is a separate stage. Today we are making the assessment clearer, not deciding a winner before we have compared the relevant evidence.

ANSWERS / EXPLANATIONS: PAGE 86

1. job-related competency | 2. role profile | 3. behavioral question | 4. scoring rubric | 5. affinity bias | 6. rating anchors | 7. structured interview | 8. candidate experience | 9. selection rationale | 10. Offer approval

A score needs an example

F Say it

A panelist awards a high teamwork score because an applicant shares a hobby. The interview notes contain no teamwork example. No hiring decision is approved.

Complete the four gaps. Use each bank entry once.

WORD + PHRASE BANK

criterion / rationale / approved / evidence

Recruiter: "A shared hobby is not job-related ¹ _____."

Manager: "We need an example against the agreed ² _____."

Recruiter: "The score needs a supported ³ _____."

Manager: "No offer has been ⁴ _____."

ANSWERS / EXPLANATIONS: PAGE 86

1. evidence | 2. criterion | 3. rationale | 4. approved

Rehearse with a fixed script

1. Read turns 1-10. Stress the client-follow-up and escalation evidence rather than confidence or shared interests.
2. Switch roles for turns 11-20. Read the common assessment criteria and candidate-update commitment without announcing a hiring outcome.
3. Complete and check the transfer. Repeat the correction from shared hobby to job-related evidence, then keep the offer unapproved.

WORKING ALONE

Read both roles, pausing for two seconds when the speaker changes. Repeat with the bank covered, then check any missed expressions.

The laptop is ready; the role is not

A Read the situation

Clarify first-month priorities, success criteria, support, and decision authority without confusing access with readiness.

New coordinator Evan has working accounts and equipment on day three, but no agreed first-month priorities. Manager Nora brings a proposed plan: review five sample cases by day ten, process live cases under supervision by day twenty, and hold a readiness review on day thirty. Sample-case checks cover required fields and the escalation route. Independent case ownership requires Nora's sign-off. The onboarding checklist currently says complete because the equipment and account tasks are finished.

PEOPLE / Evan: New coordinator | Nora: Line manager

QUESTIONS CAN SHOW OWNERSHIP

A new starter may hesitate to ask which task comes first or who can approve a decision. Clear questions reduce rework. Managers can make expectations usable by naming the deliverable, standard, support person, and review point instead of asking someone simply to be proactive.

Briefing checks

Circle one answer in each item. Use the briefing.

1. What is already complete?

- A The day-thirty readiness review
- C All role-specific learning

- B Equipment and account setup
- D Independent case approval

2. What is proposed for day ten?

- A Approve another employee's work
- C Take unrestricted ownership of every live case

- B Review five sample cases
- D Complete the day-thirty review early

3. What must precede independent case ownership?

- A Assuming every account permission is decision authority
- C Having a working laptop alone

- B Nora's sign-off
- D Reaching day three automatically

Answers and explanations: page 87.

The vocabulary that does the work

B Find the words / 1 of 2

Read the definitions and say the common word combinations aloud.

onboarding

The process of helping a new employee enter and become effective in a role.

IN USE plan the onboarding

preboarding

Preparation completed before the employee's first working day.

IN USE coordinate preboarding

orientation

An introduction to the organization, people, and basic arrangements.

IN USE attend orientation

access provisioning

Creation of the required system accounts and permissions.

IN USE confirm access provisioning

role clarity

A shared understanding of responsibilities and expected outcomes.

IN USE establish role clarity

first-month plan

A sequence of priorities and reviews for the initial month.

IN USE agree a first-month plan

deliverable

A defined piece of work to be produced.

IN USE specify the deliverable

success criterion

A stated basis for judging whether work meets expectations.

IN USE agree success criteria

milestone

A meaningful point used to track progress.

IN USE set a learning milestone

ramp-up period

The time needed to reach the expected level of contribution.

IN USE support the ramp-up period

shadowing

Observing an experienced colleague carrying out work.

IN USE arrange job shadowing

supervised practice

Performing a task with appropriate oversight and support.

IN USE schedule supervised practice

Precision check

A completed equipment checklist establishes access, not competence or decision authority. Day thirty is a review point, not an automatic promise of independent ownership. The scope and approval condition must stay visible in the plan.

The vocabulary that does the work

B Find the words / 2 of 2

Read the definitions and say the common word combinations aloud.

buddy

A colleague assigned to help with everyday orientation and questions.

IN USE assign an onboarding buddy

line manager

The person with direct managerial responsibility for an employee.

IN USE confirm the line manager

stakeholder map

A guide to people affected by or involved in the role's work.

IN USE review the stakeholder map

decision authority

Permission to make specified decisions.

IN USE clarify decision authority

escalation route

The path for referring an issue beyond one's role or authority.

IN USE identify the escalation route

dependency

Something that must be available or completed for another task to proceed.

IN USE flag a dependency

check-in

A scheduled conversation about progress, needs, or concerns.

IN USE hold a weekly check-in

feedback loop

A process of using responses to improve subsequent work.

IN USE create a feedback loop

readiness review

An assessment of preparedness for a defined responsibility.

IN USE conduct a readiness review

sign-off

Explicit confirmation or approval by the authorized person.

IN USE obtain manager sign-off

independent ownership

Responsibility for carrying out defined work without routine supervision.

IN USE confirm independent ownership

onboarding completion

Completion of a defined onboarding scope, not automatically all role learning.

IN USE qualify onboarding completion

Precision check

Five sample cases is a quantity; required fields and the escalation route are assessment criteria. A useful milestone combines the work, date, review basis, and support. Avoid describing someone as fully trained solely because a date has arrived.

Phrases you can actually use

C Notice the language / 1 of 2

DISTINGUISH SETUP

"My accounts work, but the role priorities are not yet clear."

NAME THE FIRST MILESTONE

"Review five sample cases by day ten."

SEPARATE PRACTICE STAGES

"Live cases come next, with supervision."

ASK ABOUT AUTHORITY

"Which decisions can I make, and which should I refer?"

ASK FOR SEQUENCE

"Which deliverable should I complete first?"

DEFINE THE CHECK

"We will check the required fields and the escalation route."

CLARIFY THE REVIEWER

"Nora will review the sample cases with you."

KEEP SUPPORT VISIBLE

"Bring unresolved cases to the named supervisor."

Ready

Ready for which responsibility and under what supervision?

Complete

Name the scope before using this status.

Access

A system permission is not necessarily authority to decide.

Phrases you can actually use

C Notice the language / 2 of 2

QUALIFY THE DATE

"Day thirty is a readiness review, not automatic authorization."

RAISE A DEPENDENCY

"I need the sample-case access before I can complete that milestone."

SET A CHECK-IN

"We will review progress and questions at the scheduled meeting."

READ BACK THE PLAN

"Samples first, supervised cases next, then a readiness review."

CONFIRM THE CONDITION

"Independent ownership requires manager sign-off."

AVOID VAGUE EFFORT

"Let us define what ready looks like for this responsibility."

CORRECT THE CHECKLIST

"Mark system setup complete, with role learning still in progress."

CLOSE THE AGREEMENT

"Record the milestones, support, and sign-off requirement together."

By

Gives a deadline; it does not guarantee approval on that date.

Own

Clarify responsibility and limits, not merely enthusiasm.

Review

An assessment point whose outcome is not predetermined.

Choose the precise message

D Check your understanding

Circle one best answer for each item. Use the stated purpose and case facts, not the option that merely sounds most polite.

1. Which checklist status is accurate on day three?
 - A Fully competent in every task
 - B Independent ownership approved
 - C All onboarding goals achieved
 - D System setup complete; role learning not yet complete

2. Which day-ten milestone combines quantity, timing, and an assessment basis?
 - A Open five cases by day ten and treat access as evidence of readiness.
 - B Read five cases by day ten and obtain independent authority automatically.
 - C Review the escalation guide by day ten without checking any sample cases.
 - D Review five sample cases by day ten, checking required fields and the escalation route.

3. What does the day-thirty meeting establish in advance?
 - A Automatic sign-off for independent work
 - B Proof that supervision is already unnecessary
 - C Permission to bypass unresolved questions
 - D A planned readiness assessment, not a guaranteed outcome

4. How should Evan raise missing sample access?
 - A The milestone is irrelevant because accounts exist.
 - B I need access to the sample cases to meet the day-ten milestone.
 - C The laptop works, so no dependency can exist.
 - D I will mark the cases complete without opening them.

Answers and explanations: [page 87](#).

The laptop is ready; the role is not

E Conversations / turns 1-10

Complete the numbered gaps. Use each bank entry once, without changing its form. Cover the answers at the end until you finish.

WORD + PHRASE BANK

success criteria / shadowing / escalation route / role clarity / dependency / access provisioning / sign-off / decision authority / first-month plan / readiness review

- 01 **Evan:** My accounts and laptop are working, but the checklist says onboarding is complete. I still do not know which work matters most this month.
- 02 **Nora:** The checklist only confirms ¹ _____. We need to separate that setup from your learning plan and the responsibilities you will take on.
- 03 **Evan:** That would help. I have several training links and messages from colleagues, but no clear order or definition of what I should produce first.
- 04 **Nora:** Let us agree a ² _____. Start with five sample cases by day ten, then supervised live work by day twenty.
- 05 **Evan:** What will you check in the samples? I can count five completed files, but that would not tell me whether I handled them correctly.
- 06 **Nora:** We need explicit ³ _____. I will check the required fields and whether you identified the correct escalation route for each case.
- 07 **Evan:** I also need to know what to do when a sample contains an unclear request. Should I choose an answer or bring the uncertainty to you?
- 08 **Nora:** Use the stated ⁴ _____. We are checking that you recognize the boundary, not rewarding guesses that happen to look decisive.
- 09 **Evan:** After the samples, I would like to see how a colleague handles live cases. The examples alone may not show the pace of the real queue.
- 10 **Nora:** We can arrange ⁵ _____ before your supervised cases. I will identify the colleague so you know who to ask about everyday workflow.

The conversation, continued

E Conversations / turns 11-20

Continue with the word bank on page 19.

- 11 **Evan:** Will that colleague approve my work, or will you? I do not want friendly advice to become an approval I was never actually given.
- 12 **Nora:** I retain the defined ⁶ _____. The colleague supports learning; the designated supervisor handles the live-case checks under the plan.
- 13 **Evan:** The day-thirty date sounds like a target for working independently. Should I tell other teams they can send cases directly to me from then?
- 14 **Nora:** Not yet. It is a ⁷ _____, not an automatic change in responsibility. We will assess the evidence and identify any remaining support you need.
- 15 **Evan:** I will tell the other teams it is a review date, then. What specifically has to happen before I can accept cases independently?
- 16 **Nora:** Correct. My ⁸ _____ is required for independent ownership. Account permissions alone do not change that condition, even if a system technically lets you open a case.
- 17 **Evan:** One thing is blocking the first task: I cannot open the sample-case folder. The general account works, but that folder still gives me an access error.
- 18 **Nora:** That is a ⁹ _____ for the first milestone. I will arrange the access and check progress with you rather than treating the existing setup tick as proof everything is available.
- 19 **Evan:** Let me confirm: five samples, then supervised live cases, then a readiness review. We will record the criteria and approval condition with those dates.
- 20 **Nora:** Yes. That gives us ¹⁰ _____. I will correct the checklist to say system setup complete and role learning in progress, so other teams see the same boundaries.

ANSWERS / EXPLANATIONS: PAGE 88

1. access provisioning | 2. first-month plan | 3. success criteria | 4. escalation route | 5. shadowing | 6. decision authority | 7. readiness review | 8. sign-off | 9. dependency | 10. role clarity

A date is not a sign-off

F Say it

A new employee completes account setup on Monday. Three sample cases are due Friday. Independent processing requires a supervisor review that has not yet occurred.

Complete the four gaps. Use each bank entry once.

WORD + PHRASE BANK

sample / review / confirmed / complete

Employee: "Account setup is ¹ _____."

Manager: "The next milestone is three ² _____ cases."

Employee: "Independent processing still requires a ³ _____."

Manager: "That approval is not yet ⁴ _____."

ANSWERS / EXPLANATIONS: PAGE 88

1. complete | 2. sample | 3. review | 4. confirmed

Rehearse with a fixed script

1. Read the corrected onboarding dialogue. Separate account setup from sample review, supervised work, and independent authority.
2. Switch roles. Read back five samples by day ten, supervised live work by day twenty, and a readiness review on day thirty.
3. Complete and check the transfer. Keep Friday's three-case milestone separate from the supervisor approval that has not occurred.

WORKING ALONE

Read both roles, pausing for two seconds when the speaker changes. Repeat with the bank covered, then check any missed expressions.

Two missing summaries, not a personality verdict

A Read the situation

Give specific performance feedback, invite factual context, and record an observable improvement standard.

Manager Priya and analyst Daniel review two weekly reports, dated September 11 and 18. Both omitted the summary section required by the agreed template, and Priya had to request it separately. A draft note calls Daniel careless and unmotivated. No explanation for the omissions has been established. Priya wants the next report, due September 25, to include the summary. This is a feedback meeting; no formal warning or disciplinary decision has been made.

PEOPLE / Priya: Team manager | Daniel: Analyst

DIRECT FEEDBACK CAN REMAIN RESPECTFUL

Name the work and its effect without assigning a character flaw. Invite the employee to explain the sequence and barriers. A clear expectation is easier to act on than a softened hint, while a specific record is fairer than an unsupported judgment about motivation.

Briefing checks

Circle one answer in each item. Use the briefing.

1. What was missing from the two reports?

- A A signed disciplinary warning
- C The agreed summary section

- B All supporting calculations
- D Every data table

2. What does the draft note wrongly assume?

- A That a summary was required
- C A motive and personality judgment not established by the facts

- B That the manager requested the missing sections
- D That the reports have dates

3. What is the current meeting status?

- A A completed dismissal
- C A completed appeal outcome

- B A confirmed final warning
- D Feedback without a formal disciplinary decision

Answers and explanations: [page 89](#).

The vocabulary that does the work

B Find the words / 1 of 2

03

Read the definitions and say the common word combinations aloud.

performance expectation

The standard of work or behavior required for a role.

IN USE clarify performance expectations

observable behavior

An action that can be specifically described or evidenced.

IN USE describe observable behavior

performance gap

A difference between expected and observed performance.

IN USE identify a performance gap

feedback conversation

A discussion of work, its effects, and improvement.

IN USE hold a feedback conversation

specific example

A concrete instance supporting the feedback.

IN USE give a specific example

impact statement

An explanation of the effect of the observed work or behavior.

IN USE make an impact statement

employee response

The employee's account, explanation, or comment.

IN USE record the employee response

barrier

A factor that may prevent the expected work.

IN USE explore a work barrier

attribution

An explanation assigning an outcome to a cause or person.

IN USE check the attribution

recency bias

Overweighting the most recent events when judging a longer period.

IN USE avoid recency bias

performance standard

A defined level or feature of acceptable work.

IN USE apply the performance standard

measurable objective

A target whose achievement can be checked against stated criteria.

IN USE agree a measurable objective

Precision check

The observed fact is that two dated reports lacked a required section. That supports feedback about completeness, not a conclusion that Daniel is unmotivated. An employee explanation is a reported account until the relevant facts are checked.

The vocabulary that does the work

B Find the words / 2 of 2

Read the definitions and say the common word combinations aloud.

improvement action

A specified step intended to address a performance gap.

IN USE confirm the improvement action

support commitment

Assistance the manager or organization agrees to provide.

IN USE record the support commitment

review date

The planned date for checking progress or an outcome.

IN USE set a review date

contemporaneous note

A record made at or near the time of the event.

IN USE keep a contemporaneous note

factual record

Documentation distinguishing evidence from interpretation.

IN USE maintain a factual record

acknowledgment of receipt

Confirmation that a document was received, not necessarily agreed with.

IN USE obtain acknowledgment of receipt

informal coaching

Developmental guidance outside a stated formal disciplinary stage.

IN USE provide informal coaching

formal warning

A notice issued under an applicable formal employment process.

IN USE distinguish a formal warning

performance improvement plan

A structured plan specifying improvements, support, and review arrangements.

IN USE review the performance improvement plan

calibration meeting

A discussion aligning performance ratings with common standards.

IN USE prepare for a calibration meeting

right of response

An opportunity to answer a concern under the relevant process.

IN USE provide a right of response

follow-up evidence

Later information used to assess whether the agreed change occurred.

IN USE review follow-up evidence

Precision check

Receipt of a note does not necessarily mean agreement with its contents. Label the actual meeting stage accurately. A measurable next step names the report, required section, due date, and review method without silently converting coaching into a formal warning.

Phrases you can actually use

C Notice the language / 1 of 2

03

OPEN WITH THE WORK

"I want to discuss the September 11 and 18 reports."

STATE THE IMPACT

"I had to request the summary separately before completing my review."

AVOID A MOTIVE CLAIM

"I have not established why the section was missing."

VERIFY THE DOCUMENT

"Let us compare that file with the agreed version."

NAME THE GAP

"Both reports omitted the agreed summary section."

INVITE CONTEXT

"Please walk me through how you prepared those reports."

SEPARATE THE ACCOUNT

"You explained that you used an older template."

KEEP THE STANDARD CLEAR

"The September 25 report needs the summary section."

Always

Usually overstates a pattern when only two examples are supplied.

Careless

A judgment that should not replace a description of the work.

Explained

Attributes an account without automatically verifying it.

Phrases you can actually use

C Notice the language / 2 of 2

03

OFFER SPECIFIC SUPPORT

"I will send the current template and confirm the required section."

CORRECT THE LABEL

"The note should describe the omissions, not call you unmotivated."

CLARIFY THE STAGE

"This meeting is feedback, not a formal warning."

CLOSE THE NEXT STEP

"Confirm the report date, required section, and review arrangement."

DEFINE THE CHECK

"We will review completeness against that template."

PRESERVE DISAGREEMENT

"We can record your response without pretending we agree on every point."

DISTINGUISH RECEIPT

"Acknowledging receipt does not necessarily mean agreeing with the note."

ASSESS THE FOLLOW-UP

"Judge the next submission against the agreed standard."

Agreed

Specify agreement on the standard, facts, or action.

Received

Does not by itself mean accepted as accurate.

Improved

Identify the evidence and comparison supporting the claim.

Choose the precise message

D Check your understanding

Circle one best answer for each item. Use the stated purpose and case facts, not the option that merely sounds most polite.

1. Which opening is most precise?

- A** The September 11 and 18 reports omitted the required summary.
- B** You never care about your work.
- C** Your personality is the problem.
- D** Every report you have ever written is wrong.

2. Which note preserves the distinction between an account and a verified cause?

- A** Daniel admitted carelessness by confirming that the summary was missing.
- B** The manager verified a template error when Daniel described the file.
- C** Daniel said he used an older template; comparison with the current file is pending.
- D** The older template caused both omissions; no comparison is needed.

3. Which objective is measurable?

- A** Never have another difficulty of any kind.
- B** Include the required summary in the September 25 report and check it against the agreed template.
- C** Care much more from now on.
- D** Become a better person immediately.

4. What does a receipt acknowledgment alone establish?

- A** Every statement in it is agreed
- B** A formal warning was issued
- C** The employee waived every possible concern
- D** The note was received

Answers and explanations: [page 89](#).

Two missing summaries, not a personality verdict

E Conversations / turns 1-10

Complete the numbered gaps. Use each bank entry once, without changing its form. Cover the answers at the end until you finish.

WORD + PHRASE BANK

employee response / performance gap / follow-up evidence / impact statement / factual record / measurable objective / acknowledgment of receipt / informal coaching / performance standard / support commitment

- 01 **Priya:** Thanks for meeting with me. The reports dated September eleventh and eighteenth both omitted the required summary. I had to request it separately before finishing my review.
- 02 **Daniel:** I understand the ¹ _____. The tables were there, but the summary was not. I am concerned about the draft note calling me careless and unmotivated.
- 03 **Priya:** You are right to question those words. I can describe what was missing and its effect, but I have not established your motivation.
- 04 **Daniel:** Please keep the ² _____ about the extra requests. That is specific. The character labels suggest you have already decided why the omissions happened.
- 05 **Priya:** I will remove them. Before I revise the note, can you show me the file you used and explain how you prepared the reports?
- 06 **Daniel:** Yes. My ³ _____ is that I used an older template without a summary heading. I will send it, but we have not compared the versions yet.
- 07 **Priya:** Then I will attribute that explanation to you and mark the version check outstanding. I will not record a template fault as already proven.
- 08 **Daniel:** That makes the ⁴ _____ clearer. Please also retain the dates and the fact that I supplied the summary after you requested it.
- 09 **Priya:** For September twenty-fifth, the report needs the summary as well as the supporting tables. I will review it against the current agreed template.
- 10 **Daniel:** The ⁵ _____ is clear, but I need that version. Could you send the file rather than just the folder name, so we compare the same document?

The conversation, continued

E Conversations / turns 11-20

03

Continue with the word bank on page 28.

- 11 **Priya:** I will send it today and identify the required heading. We will also check whether the shared folder still contains an outdated copy.
- 12 **Daniel:** Please include that ⁶ _____ in the note. I will check the required section before submission and raise any unresolved version difference before the deadline.
- 13 **Priya:** Agreed. The next step is a complete report on September twenty-fifth, checked against that file. It is not an instruction simply to show more enthusiasm.
- 14 **Daniel:** I can work to that ⁷ _____. If the current file still leaves something unclear, I will ask before submitting rather than omit the section again.
- 15 **Priya:** I also need to correct the meeting label. This is a feedback discussion; no formal warning or other disciplinary decision has been made.
- 16 **Daniel:** Then please label it ⁸ _____, not a warning. I want the record to show the actual stage as well as the work we discussed.
- 17 **Priya:** I will send the revised note for you to check. Please identify any remaining factual errors and let me know that you received it.
- 18 **Daniel:** I can give an ⁹ _____ without agreeing to wording I still dispute. Will you keep my response with the note if something remains unresolved?
- 19 **Priya:** Yes. I will preserve your actual response. We will judge progress from the next submission against the agreed requirement, not from receipt of this note.
- 20 **Daniel:** Understood. The September twenty-fifth report will provide the ¹⁰ _____. Today I will send my earlier template, and you will send the current one.

ANSWERS / EXPLANATIONS: PAGE 90

1. performance gap | 2. impact statement | 3. employee response | 4. factual record | 5. performance standard | 6. support commitment | 7. measurable objective | 8. informal coaching | 9. acknowledgment of receipt | 10. follow-up evidence

Record the event, not a motive

F Say it

Two timesheets lacked project codes. The employee says the code list was unavailable; this has not been verified. The next timesheet must include the codes by Friday.

Complete the four gaps. Use each bank entry once.

WORD + PHRASE BANK

codes / unavailable / Friday / verified

Manager: "Two timesheets omitted the project ¹ _____."

Employee: "My explanation is that the list was ² _____."

Manager: "That explanation still needs to be ³ _____."

Employee: "The corrected next timesheet is due ⁴ _____."

ANSWERS / EXPLANATIONS: PAGE 90

1. codes | 2. unavailable | 3. verified | 4. Friday

Rehearse with a fixed script

1. Read turns 1-10, distinguishing dated omissions from character judgments and an employee account from a verified template fault.
2. Switch roles for turns 11-20. Stress September 25, the current template, and receipt without forced agreement.
3. Complete and check the transfer. Attribute the unavailable-code-list explanation to the employee and retain Friday's required codes.

WORKING ALONE

Read both roles, pausing for two seconds when the speaker changes. Repeat with the bank covered, then check any missed expressions.

Receive the concern without deciding the case

04

A Read the situation

Listen empathetically, attribute accounts accurately, and explain process limits without promising secrecy or a finding.

Employee Tomas tells HR adviser Imani that colleague Reed excluded him from two project meetings and made a dismissive comment on September 15. Tomas recalls the words but has not supplied the invitations or messages. He thinks another colleague may have heard the comment; that has not been checked. Imani is receiving the first account, not deciding whether misconduct occurred. Tomas asks whether the conversation can remain entirely secret and whether Reed will be disciplined.

PEOPLE / Tomas: Employee raising a concern | Imani: HR adviser

EMPATHY IS NOT A VERDICT

Thank someone for raising a concern and explain what you can do next. Taking the account seriously does not require declaring it proven. Equally, an incomplete record is not a reason to dismiss the person. Be candid about appropriate information sharing and avoid guarantees about another employee.

Briefing checks

Circle one answer in each item. Use the briefing.

1. What evidence is available at the start?

- A** Verified invitations and message records
- C** A completed investigation finding

B Tomas's initial account

D Confirmed witness testimony from everyone present

2. What is Imani's role in this conversation?

- A** Guarantee that no one else will ever know
- C** Announce Reed's discipline

B Receive and clarify the concern

D Decide a legal claim immediately

3. What is known about the possible witness?

A The colleague issued a disciplinary decision.

B Tomas thinks someone may have heard the comment.

C The colleague has already confirmed every word.

D The colleague has denied being present.

Answers and explanations: page 91.

The vocabulary that does the work

B Find the words / 1 of 2

Read the definitions and say the common word combinations aloud.

employee relations

Work addressing the employment relationship and workplace concerns.

IN USE manage employee-relations concerns

intake

The initial receipt and clarification of a concern.

IN USE conduct an intake conversation

allegation

A claim about conduct that requires appropriate assessment.

IN USE record an allegation

complainant

A person raising a complaint under a defined process.

IN USE contact the complainant

respondent

A person responding to an allegation under the relevant process.

IN USE hear the respondent's account

firsthand account

Information from someone who directly experienced or observed an event.

IN USE distinguish a firsthand account

reported account

Information attributed to the person who supplied it.

IN USE attribute a reported account

corroboration

Independent information supporting an account.

IN USE seek corroboration

contemporaneous record

A document or note created at or near the event.

IN USE preserve contemporaneous records

chronology

Events arranged in time order.

IN USE establish the chronology

witness

Someone who may have relevant knowledge about an event.

IN USE identify a possible witness

neutral question

A question that does not assume the desired answer or conclusion.

IN USE ask a neutral question

Precision check

Write Tomas reported that he was excluded, not Reed deliberately excluded Tomas as an established finding. Record exact words only when they are actually supplied, and label uncertain recollection. A possible witness is not yet corroboration.

The vocabulary that does the work

B Find the words / 2 of 2

Read the definitions and say the common word combinations aloud.

leading question

A question suggesting the answer or assuming a contested fact.

IN USE avoid leading questions

scope of inquiry

The issues and boundaries to be examined.

IN USE define the scope of inquiry

impartiality

An approach not favoring a person or predetermined conclusion.

IN USE maintain impartiality

conflict of interest

A connection or interest that could compromise fair handling.

IN USE disclose a conflict of interest

confidentiality

Appropriate protection and restricted handling of information.

IN USE explain confidentiality limits

need-to-know basis

Sharing information with people who require it for a legitimate purpose.

IN USE share on a need-to-know basis

retaliation concern

A concern about adverse treatment connected to protected conduct or reporting.

IN USE raise a retaliation concern

interim measure

A temporary arrangement pending review, not itself a finding.

IN USE explain an interim measure

evidence preservation

Keeping relevant original information available and intact.

IN USE arrange evidence preservation

finding

A conclusion reached through the applicable assessment process.

IN USE distinguish a finding from an allegation

substantiated

Supported under the relevant process and evidential standard.

IN USE explain a substantiated finding

case update

Information about the progress or status of a concern.

IN USE provide a case update

Precision check

Appropriate confidentiality is different from absolute secrecy. Explain the actual sharing limits and process without imposing a blanket gag rule or restricting protected reporting. An interim arrangement or an intake note does not prove guilt or determine discipline.

Phrases you can actually use

C Notice the language / 1 of 2

ACKNOWLEDGE THE CONCERN

"Thank you for bringing this to me."

CLARIFY DIRECT KNOWLEDGE

"Which parts did you personally see or hear?"

REQUEST THE RECORD

"Please identify the relevant invitations and messages."

KEEP THE WITNESS STATUS OPEN

"We have not yet heard from the possible witness."

INVITE THE SEQUENCE

"Please describe what happened and when."

SEPARATE RECOLLECTION

"Are those the exact words you remember, or a summary?"

ATTRIBUTE THE ACCOUNT

"I will record this as your account of the events."

AVOID PREJUDGMENT

"I cannot determine the outcome from this conversation alone."

Reported

Identifies the source without deciding the truth of the claim.

Alleged

Describes a claim under review, not an insult or a dismissal.

Confirmed

Requires adequate verification, not repetition of one account.

Phrases you can actually use

C Notice the language / 2 of 2

EXPLAIN INFORMATION HANDLING

"I will handle the information carefully and explain appropriate sharing."

CLARIFY THE NEXT STEP

"The concern will go through the applicable review process."

PRESERVE THE ORIGINAL

"Keep the relevant messages in their original form."

SET A REALISTIC UPDATE

"I will contact you on Friday with the current process status."

AVOID AN ABSOLUTE PROMISE

"I cannot promise that no one else will need to know."

KEEP REPORTING AVAILABLE

"Please raise any further concern, including possible retaliation."

DISTINGUISH A TEMPORARY MEASURE

"A temporary arrangement is not itself a finding."

CHECK THE NOTE

"Please tell me if my summary misstates what you reported."

Confidential

Does not mean that relevant people can never receive information.

Unsubstantiated

Does not automatically mean deliberately false.

Resolved

Clarify whether the process ended, an action occurred, or the person feels satisfied.

Choose the precise message

D Check your understanding

Circle one best answer for each item. Use the stated purpose and case facts, not the option that merely sounds most polite.

1. Which intake note is most accurate?

- A** Tomas reported exclusion from two meetings; invitations have not yet been reviewed.
- B** Reed is guilty because Tomas spoke first.
- C** No concern exists because documents are missing.
- D** Every colleague confirmed deliberate exclusion.

2. Which question avoids adding facts to the September 15 account?

- A** Which confirmed witness has already verified your recollection?
- B** What punishment would address the misconduct we have established?
- C** Where did the comment occur, who was present, and which words do you recall?
- D** At the September 15 meeting, why did Reed deliberately exclude you again?

3. What is the best response to a request for total secrecy?

- A** Explain careful handling and the limits of necessary, appropriate sharing.
- B** Promise that no person can ever learn anything.
- C** Publish the account to the whole team.
- D** Require silence about every concern in every setting.

4. What does a temporary separation arrangement establish by itself?

- A** That the respondent has admitted the conduct
- B** That no review is needed
- C** A temporary process measure, not a finding of guilt
- D** That every allegation is proven

Answers and explanations: [page 91](#).

Receive the concern without deciding the case

E Conversations / turns 1-10

Complete the numbered gaps. Use each bank entry once, without changing its form. Cover the answers at the end until you finish.

WORD + PHRASE BANK

case update / need-to-know basis / chronology / witness / evidence preservation / firsthand account / confidentiality / intake / allegation / retaliation concern

- 01 **Tomas:** I was left out of two project meetings, and Reed made a dismissive comment on September fifteenth. I am worried that bringing this up will make things worse.
- 02 **Imani:** Thank you for telling me. This ¹ _____ is for understanding your account and explaining next steps, not announcing a conclusion.
- 03 **Tomas:** I can describe the comment, although I would like a moment to remember the exact words. I do not have the invitations open right now.
- 04 **Imani:** We can build a ² _____ first. Please separate what you remember clearly from anything you are unsure about, and identify the meetings as specifically as you can.
- 05 **Tomas:** The comment was said directly to me. The reason I think I was excluded from the meetings is that I heard about them afterward from someone else.
- 06 **Imani:** That distinction matters. The comment is part of your ³ _____, while the meeting information has another source. I will not combine them as though you directly observed everything.
- 07 **Tomas:** There was a colleague nearby. I can give you the name, but I have not asked what they heard, so I cannot say they will confirm my account.
- 08 **Imani:** I will identify them as a possible ⁴ _____. We have not heard their account, so the note should not present their involvement as independent confirmation.
- 09 **Tomas:** Can you keep this entirely secret? I am uneasy about Reed hearing a different version of what I said before I have checked the summary.
- 10 **Imani:** I will explain the limits of ⁵ _____. I will handle the information carefully, but others may need to know to address the concern.

The conversation, continued

E Conversations / turns 11-20

Continue with the word bank on page 37.

- 11 **Tomas:** I am still uneasy about who will hear this. Can you explain who may need the information and whom I should contact if anything changes?
- 12 **Imani:** Appropriate sharing should be on a ⁶ _____. I will explain the process and contact route without restricting protected reporting rights.
- 13 **Tomas:** Will Reed be disciplined? Part of me wants a clear answer now, but I realize you have only heard from me.
- 14 **Imani:** We have an ⁷ _____, not a finding. The relevant review needs to examine the information fairly, and I cannot promise a particular outcome from this conversation.
- 15 **Tomas:** I can provide the messages and identify the invitations I expected. Some details may support my interpretation, while others may show something I did not know.
- 16 **Imani:** Preserve the originals for ⁸ _____. We need the actual records, including context, rather than edited extracts that accidentally leave out information relevant to the concern.
- 17 **Tomas:** My biggest worry is what happens after I raise this. If my assignments suddenly change, I would want someone to examine that rather than assume it is unrelated.
- 18 **Imani:** Please report any ⁹ _____ through the available route. We should record the facts and assess the concern, not pre-decide either that retaliation occurred or that it could not occur.
- 19 **Tomas:** Before we finish, could you read back the main points? I want the note to distinguish my recollection, what I inferred, and what still needs checking.
- 20 **Imani:** Yes, and I will give you a ¹⁰ _____ on Friday. That is a commitment to communicate the status, not a promise that the review or an outcome will be complete then.

ANSWERS / EXPLANATIONS: PAGE 92

1. intake | 2. chronology | 3. firsthand account | 4. witness | 5. confidentiality | 6. need-to-know basis | 7. allegation | 8. evidence preservation | 9. retaliation concern | 10. case update

A report is not yet corroboration

F Say it

An employee reports a comment and names a possible witness. The witness has not been contacted. HR has promised a Tuesday status update, not an outcome.

Complete the four gaps. Use each bank entry once.

WORD + PHRASE BANK

update / contacted / finding / account

Adviser: "The note records the employee's ¹ _____."

Manager: "The possible witness has not yet been ² _____."

Adviser: "The review has not produced a ³ _____."

Manager: "Tuesday is the promised status ⁴ _____."

ANSWERS / EXPLANATIONS: PAGE 92

1. account | 2. contacted | 3. finding | 4. update

Rehearse with a fixed script

1. Read the intake conversation with a partner. Attribute Tomas's account and keep the possible witness unconfirmed.
2. Switch roles for turns 11-20. Read the limits of confidentiality and Friday's status-update promise without adding a discipline outcome.
3. Complete and check the transfer. Contrast account, uncontacted witness, and finding, then stress update in the last line.

WORKING ALONE

Read both roles, pausing for two seconds when the speaker changes. Repeat with the bank covered, then check any missed expressions.

The midpoint is not an automatic salary

A Read the situation

Explain pay-range calculations and policy criteria while keeping fairness concerns and individual decisions open.

05

Employee Alex earns a USD 72,000 annual base salary in a role with a published USD 60,000-100,000 range. Alex assumes the USD 80,000 midpoint is what everyone should receive. HR partner Maya has a fictional policy stating that placement depends on role level, relevant experience, and an internal-equity review; midpoint placement is not automatic. A separate 5% target bonus is conditional, not guaranteed. No individual pay-review outcome or discrimination finding is supplied.

PEOPLE / Alex: Employee | Maya: HR partner

EXPLAIN WITHOUT SHUTTING DOWN THE CONCERN

A correct calculation does not settle whether an individual pay decision is fair. Explain the range and the review process, then address the actual question. Avoid using policy language as a way to dismiss a concern, promise a raise, or discourage legitimate discussion of pay.

Briefing checks

Circle one answer in each item. Use the briefing.

1. What is the range midpoint?

A USD 60,000

B USD 100,000

C USD 80,000

D USD 72,000

2. What does the fictional policy say about midpoint placement?

A It replaces the individual review.

B It is not automatic.

C Everyone must immediately receive it.

D It equals the guaranteed bonus.

3. What is the status of the 5% target bonus?

A Included in the stated base salary

B A confirmed salary increase

C Conditional, not guaranteed

D Already paid

Answers and explanations: [page 93](#).

The vocabulary that does the work

B Find the words / 1 of 2

Read the definitions and say the common word combinations aloud.

base salary

Fixed contractual salary before separate variable payments and benefits.

IN USE state the annual base salary

salary range

The stated minimum-to-maximum pay interval for a defined role or level.

IN USE publish a salary range

range minimum

The lower bound of the defined pay range.

IN USE identify the range minimum

range maximum

The upper bound of the defined pay range.

IN USE identify the range maximum

midpoint

The central value of the defined range.

IN USE calculate the midpoint

compa-ratio

Base salary divided by the relevant range midpoint.

IN USE calculate the compa-ratio

range penetration

The share of the minimum-to-maximum interval reached by the salary.

IN USE calculate range penetration

pay grade

A category grouping roles within a compensation structure.

IN USE confirm the pay grade

job level

A defined category of responsibility and scope.

IN USE verify the job level

job evaluation

Assessment of a role's relative requirements or value within a structure.

IN USE conduct a job evaluation

market benchmark

External pay information used for a defined comparison.

IN USE review the market benchmark

internal equity

Consistency and fairness of pay relationships within an organization.

IN USE review internal equity

Precision check

The midpoint is $(60,000 + 100,000) / 2 = 80,000$. Compa-ratio is $72,000 / 80,000 = 90\%$. Range penetration is $(72,000 - 60,000) / (100,000 - 60,000) = 30\%$. The two percentages answer different questions.

The vocabulary that does the work

B Find the words / 2 of 2

Read the definitions and say the common word combinations aloud.

pay compression

A narrowing of pay differences between roles or experience levels.

IN USE examine pay compression

pay disparity

A difference in compensation requiring a defined comparison and context.

IN USE investigate a pay disparity

pay transparency

Openness about pay information, ranges, or decision processes.

IN USE explain pay transparency

merit increase

A pay increase linked to performance under the applicable policy.

IN USE review a merit increase

promotion increase

A pay change associated with moving to a higher-level role.

IN USE distinguish a promotion increase

market adjustment

A pay change intended to address relevant external market positioning.

IN USE assess a market adjustment

variable pay

Compensation dependent on specified results or conditions.

IN USE distinguish variable pay

target bonus

A reference bonus amount subject to the plan's actual conditions.

IN USE explain the target bonus

total cash compensation

Base pay plus the relevant cash incentive payments.

IN USE define total cash compensation

total rewards

The wider package of pay, benefits, and other employment value.

IN USE describe total rewards

benefits eligibility

The conditions for participating in a particular benefit.

IN USE confirm benefits eligibility

compensation review

A process for examining pay under the relevant criteria.

IN USE request a compensation review

Precision check

Five percent of 72,000 is a 3,600 target bonus, not guaranteed pay. Being inside a range does not by itself establish fair or lawful treatment; being below midpoint does not by itself establish an error. Review the actual criteria and facts.

Phrases you can actually use

C Notice the language / 1 of 2

ACKNOWLEDGE THE QUESTION

"I understand why the published midpoint prompted your question."

EXPLAIN THE RANGE

"The published range runs from 60,000 to 100,000."

SEPARATE POLICY FROM INFERENCE

"The policy does not promise midpoint pay to every employee."

DEFINE THE RATIO

"Your base salary is 90% of the midpoint."

STATE THE BASE

"Your annual base salary is 72,000 dollars."

CALCULATE THE CENTER

"The midpoint is 80,000 dollars."

NAME THE CRITERIA

"Placement uses role level, relevant experience, and an internal-equity review."

AVOID A PERCENTAGE MIX-UP

"Thirty percent is range penetration, not the compa-ratio."

Range

Describes an interval, not each employee's individual entitlement.

Midpoint

A reference value, not necessarily the average actual salary.

Target

An incentive reference, not guaranteed payment.

Phrases you can actually use

C Notice the language / 2 of 2

SEPARATE THE BONUS

"The 5% target is conditional variable pay."

AVOID GUARANTEED TOTALS

"A target total is not a promise of the actual payout."

INVITE THE SPECIFIC CONCERN

"Which aspect of the placement or comparison would you like reviewed?"

AVOID AN UNSUPPORTED OUTCOME

"I cannot promise a raise before the review."

QUANTIFY THE TARGET

"At this base salary, the target amount is 3,600 dollars."

KEEP FAIRNESS OPEN

"These calculations do not settle your individual equity concern."

USE THE PROPER ROUTE

"I can explain the compensation-review process and required facts."

CLOSE WITH ACCOUNTABILITY

"I will confirm the review owner and next update."

Equity

Requires relevant comparisons and context, not a single ratio.

Within range

Does not settle all fairness or legal questions.

Review

A process whose individual result remains to be determined.

Choose the precise message

D Check your understanding

Circle one best answer for each item. Use the stated purpose and case facts, not the option that merely sounds most polite.

1. What is Alex's compa-ratio?

- A** 120%
- B** 90%
- C** 30%
- D** 5%

2. What does 30% represent here?

- A** The guaranteed annual raise
- B** The employee's actual bonus payout
- C** Salary position across the 60,000-100,000 interval
- D** Salary as a share of the midpoint

3. Which statement handles the fairness question properly?

- A** Below midpoint proves discrimination without further facts.
- B** Discussing the range automatically approves a raise.
- C** The range calculation does not replace review of your individual concern.
- D** Inside the range means every possible concern is invalid.

4. Alex adds the conditional bonus to base and divides 75,600 by 80,000. What is wrong with calling 94.5% the base-pay compa-ratio?

- A** That numerator includes a target incentive; the stated base-pay ratio remains $72,000 / 80,000 = 90\%$.
- B** Nothing; target incentives always become fixed base salary.
- C** The denominator should be the 40,000 range width for a compa-ratio.
- D** The arithmetic should produce 30%, because all range comparisons are identical.

Answers and explanations: [page 93](#).

The midpoint is not an automatic salary

E Conversations / turns 1-10

Complete the numbered gaps. Use each bank entry once, without changing its form. Cover the answers at the end until you finish.

05

WORD + PHRASE BANK

midpoint / base salary / compensation review / internal equity / pay disparity / total rewards / target bonus / compa-ratio / range penetration / variable pay

- 01 **Alex:** My base is seventy-two thousand dollars, but the published range has an eighty-thousand midpoint. Does that mean my salary is eight thousand short of what it should be?
- 02 **Maya:** It means your ¹ _____ is eight thousand below that reference. It does not, by itself, tell us whether your placement followed the policy correctly.
- 03 **Alex:** I read the middle of the range as the standard salary everyone should receive. Is that not what the figure means?
- 04 **Maya:** Not under this policy. The ² _____ is eighty thousand, while placement depends on role level, relevant experience, and an internal-equity review. It is not automatic.
- 05 **Alex:** The statement shows ninety percent in one place and thirty percent in another. I thought at least one comparison must be wrong.
- 06 **Maya:** Your ³ _____ is ninety percent: seventy-two thousand divided by eighty thousand. That percentage compares base pay with the midpoint, not with the range width.
- 07 **Alex:** Show me how thirty percent works, please. I do not want to challenge a calculation simply because it uses a different reference.
- 08 **Maya:** Your ⁴ _____ uses twelve thousand above the sixty-thousand minimum, divided by the forty-thousand interval. Both figures can be correct because their denominators differ.
- 09 **Alex:** That answers the arithmetic. My concern is that my relevant experience was missed when my placement was set. Can somebody check that?
- 10 **Maya:** Yes, I will identify the owner for a ⁵ _____ and the facts they need. Being inside the range is not a reason to close your concern.

The conversation, continued

E Conversations / turns 11-20

Continue with the word bank on page 46.

- 11 **Alex:** I also want the comparison to use roles with similar responsibilities. I am not asking you to disclose another employee's personal record.
- 12 **Maya:** That is relevant to ⁶ _____. The review needs the appropriate comparisons and policy criteria. I cannot promise its conclusion before those have been examined.
- 13 **Alex:** The five-percent bonus would add thirty-six hundred. Can I describe seventy-five thousand six hundred as my guaranteed annual cash amount?
- 14 **Maya:** No. The ⁷ _____ is conditional. The calculation gives the target amount, but the plan's conditions determine the actual payment, which is not confirmed here.
- 15 **Alex:** Then I will label that total base plus target, not guaranteed cash. Does the bonus increase my salary comparison from ninety percent to ninety-four point five?
- 16 **Maya:** No. This ratio uses base salary, not ⁸ _____. Adding a conditional incentive changes the numerator and stops it being the base-pay compa-ratio we calculated.
- 17 **Alex:** That distinction helps. Please show the benefits separately as well; I do not want to add every package item to my salary figure.
- 18 **Maya:** They belong in the wider ⁹ _____ statement. That can explain the package without pretending every benefit is an extra dollar of base pay.
- 19 **Alex:** Please confirm the reviewer and next contact date. I want the experience question addressed, even though neither the midpoint nor the bonus promises a raise.
- 20 **Maya:** I will confirm those details and retain your ¹⁰ _____ concern for review. We have explained the numbers, not reached a finding about your individual placement.

ANSWERS / EXPLANATIONS: PAGE 94

1. base salary | 2. midpoint | 3. compa-ratio | 4. range penetration | 5. compensation review | 6. internal equity | 7. target bonus | 8. variable pay | 9. total rewards | 10. pay disparity

A ratio and a target

F Say it

Annual base salary is USD 54,000, the range midpoint is USD 60,000, and the conditional target bonus is 10% of base. No actual payout is confirmed.

Complete the four gaps. Use each bank entry once.

WORD + PHRASE BANK

dollars / ninety / unconfirmed / guaranteed

Employee: "My compa-ratio is ¹ _____ percent."

HR: "The target bonus is 5,400 ² _____."

Employee: "That target is not ³ _____."

HR: "The actual payout remains ⁴ _____."

ANSWERS / EXPLANATIONS: PAGE 94

1. ninety | 2. dollars | 3. guaranteed | 4. unconfirmed

Rehearse with a fixed script

1. Read turns 1-10. Contrast 90% of midpoint with 30% through the range, saying the denominator for each.
2. Switch roles for turns 11-20. Correct the proposed 94.5% base-pay ratio and keep the bonus conditional.
3. Complete and check the transfer. State 90% and the 5,400-dollar target without promising its payment.

WORKING ALONE

Read both roles, pausing for two seconds when the speaker changes. Repeat with the bank covered, then check any missed expressions.

Received is not approved or refused

A Read the situation

Acknowledge a work-adjustment request promptly and explain an individualized review without collecting unnecessary sensitive information.

Manager Sana receives a request from an employee to start at 9:30 rather than 8:30 from October 7 for a health-related reason. HR adviser Ben has not reviewed it. The request gives the desired schedule but does not explain the work barrier or coverage implications. No decision or temporary arrangement is approved. Sana asks whether the request is automatically accepted, or whether the standard-hours policy permits an immediate refusal. Ben must clarify the process and information boundaries.

PEOPLE / Sana: Department manager | Ben: HR adviser

06

BE PROMPT WITHOUT PRETENDING CERTAINTY

Acknowledge the request and arrange the appropriate discussion. A standard rule does not answer every individual case, and a request does not itself establish a decision. Ask about relevant work needs through the correct process; avoid making an employee disclose sensitive details in a team forum.

Briefing checks

Circle one answer in each item. Use the briefing.

1. What change has the employee requested?

- A An approved change for every employee
- C A 9:30 start instead of 8:30 from October 7

- B A completed medical determination
- D A confirmed permanent promotion

2. What is the current status?

- A Automatically accepted
- C Implemented as a temporary arrangement

- B Formally refused after review
- D Received but not yet reviewed or decided

3. Which information still needs appropriate clarification?

- A The work barrier and relevant coverage implications
- C A predetermined reason to deny the request

- B The employee's complete private history for the whole team
- D A diagnosis invented by the manager

Answers and explanations: page 95.

The vocabulary that does the work

B Find the words / 1 of 2

Read the definitions and say the common word combinations aloud.

accommodation request

A request for a change addressing a relevant workplace barrier under applicable rules.

IN USE acknowledge an accommodation request

work adjustment

A change to working arrangements intended to address a stated need.

IN USE discuss a work adjustment

interactive process

A discussion to clarify needs and explore an effective arrangement.

IN USE engage in the interactive process

essential function

A fundamental duty of the position under the applicable framework.

IN USE identify essential functions

functional limitation

A restriction affecting the performance of an activity.

IN USE clarify a functional limitation

workplace barrier

A feature of work that creates a relevant difficulty or limitation.

IN USE identify a workplace barrier

individualized assessment

A review of the particular person's circumstances and work needs.

IN USE conduct an individualized assessment

effective accommodation

An arrangement that addresses the relevant barrier.

IN USE assess an effective accommodation

alternative arrangement

Another proposed way of addressing the stated need.

IN USE explore an alternative arrangement

modified schedule

A change to the employee's usual work hours or timing.

IN USE assess a modified schedule

coverage requirement

A stated need for staffing or task availability at particular times.

IN USE clarify coverage requirements

interim arrangement

A temporary measure pending a fuller decision or review.

IN USE confirm an interim arrangement

Precision check

The requested start date is not an approved implementation date. Acknowledgment confirms receipt, not acceptance or refusal. An individualized process should clarify the relevant barrier and work requirements rather than treating a general schedule rule as the entire decision.

The vocabulary that does the work

B Find the words / 2 of 2

Read the definitions and say the common word combinations aloud.

implementation date

The date an authorized arrangement is to begin.

IN USE confirm the implementation date

review checkpoint

A planned point for checking progress or effectiveness.

IN USE set a review checkpoint

supporting documentation

Relevant information used to assess a request under the proper process.

IN USE handle supporting documentation

medical confidentiality

Appropriate protection of medical information.

IN USE preserve medical confidentiality

restricted access

Limiting information access to authorized people and purposes.

IN USE maintain restricted access

data minimization

Collecting only information needed for the legitimate purpose.

IN USE apply data minimization

policy owner

The person or function responsible for a policy's interpretation and upkeep.

IN USE consult the policy owner

policy exception

An authorized departure from a general rule, where applicable.

IN USE document a policy exception

undue hardship

Under the US disability framework, significant difficulty or expense assessed in context.

IN USE assess undue hardship

request status

The current stage of a request, distinct from its outcome.

IN USE communicate request status

decision rationale

The supported explanation for an authorized decision.

IN USE document the decision rationale

review route

The applicable path for questioning or revisiting a decision.

IN USE explain the review route

06

Precision check

Do not request a full medical history in a group email. Any necessary supporting information must follow the appropriate confidential process. The book does not determine eligibility, effectiveness, undue hardship, or what information a real employer may lawfully require.

Phrases you can actually use

C Notice the language / 1 of 2

ACKNOWLEDGE PROMPTLY

"We have received your request and will arrange the appropriate discussion."

CLARIFY THE NEED

"What work barrier is the requested schedule intended to address?"

USE THE RIGHT CHANNEL

"Any necessary sensitive information should go through the designated confidential route."

AVOID AUTOMATIC APPROVAL

"Receipt of a request is not confirmation of the arrangement."

STATE THE STATUS

"The request has not yet been reviewed or decided."

SEPARATE DATES

"October 7 is the requested start date, not a confirmed implementation date."

AVOID A BLANKET REFUSAL

"The standard-hours policy does not replace an individual review."

IDENTIFY THE WORK NEED

"We need a clear description of the relevant coverage requirements."

06

Requested

Describes what the employee asks for, not a completed decision.

Reasonable

A framework-dependent assessment, not a casual synonym for convenient.

Effective

Addresses the actual barrier, not merely the appearance of action.

Phrases you can actually use

C Notice the language / 2 of 2

EXPLORE ALTERNATIVES

"An alternative must address the actual barrier, not merely be easier to offer."

PROTECT THE INFORMATION

"Share only what is appropriate for the person's role in the process."

GIVE A REALISTIC CHECKPOINT

"I will confirm the next review step and contact date."

EXPLAIN THE OUTCOME PROPERLY

"Communicate the actual decision and its supported rationale through the proper process."

KEEP AUTHORITY CLEAR

"Confirm who can approve an interim arrangement."

LIMIT THE MANAGER'S QUESTION

"I need the relevant work information, not a team-wide medical explanation."

DISTINGUISH RECOMMENDATION

"A proposed arrangement is not yet an authorized change."

KEEP QUESTIONS POSSIBLE

"Explain the available review route without discouraging the request."

06

Temporary

Still needs clear scope, authority, and timing.

Medical

Sensitive information, not ordinary team-update content.

Policy

Apply with relevant law and individual facts; do not assume it answers everything.

Choose the precise message

D Check your understanding

Circle one best answer for each item. Use the stated purpose and case facts, not the option that merely sounds most polite.

1. Which first response is appropriate?

- A** Refuse automatically because a standard schedule exists.
- B** Acknowledge receipt and arrange the relevant discussion without promising the outcome.
- C** Tell the team the employee's health details.
- D** Approve automatically without review.

2. How should October 7 be described now?

- A** Proof that review is unnecessary
- B** The requested start date
- C** The approved implementation date
- D** The date of a completed refusal

3. Which information request respects the stated boundary?

- A** Collect unrelated private information just in case.
- B** Clarify the work barrier and use the designated route for any necessary sensitive support.
- C** Ask the employee to publish their complete medical history.
- D** Ask coworkers to guess a diagnosis.

4. HR proposes a different arrangement from the requested 9:30 start. What needs checking?

- A** Whether it addresses the actual barrier while meeting the relevant work requirements under the applicable process.
- B** Whether it is called flexible, which establishes that it is effective.
- C** Whether colleagues prefer it, which replaces individual assessment.
- D** Whether it avoids a schedule change, which establishes that no barrier remains.

Answers and explanations: page 95.

Received is not approved or refused

E Conversations / turns 1-10

Complete the numbered gaps. Use each bank entry once, without changing its form. Cover the answers at the end until you finish.

WORD + PHRASE BANK

request status / interactive process / workplace barrier / interim arrangement / essential functions / medical confidentiality / individualized assessment / decision rationale / accommodation request / implementation date

06

- 01 **Sana:** An employee has asked to start at nine thirty instead of eight thirty from October seventh for a health-related reason. Does receiving the message mean I should approve it?
- 02 **Ben:** No. Acknowledge the ¹ _____ promptly and arrange the appropriate discussion. We have not reviewed the individual circumstances or approved an arrangement.
- 03 **Sana:** Our handbook lists the standard hours. I wondered whether I could simply quote that section and say the schedule cannot change.
- 04 **Ben:** The rule does not replace an ² _____. We need to understand the relevant need and work requirements, not jump from the existence of standard hours to a final refusal.
- 05 **Sana:** The message gives the preferred schedule, but not the difficulty it is intended to address. I want to ask a useful question without becoming intrusive.
- 06 **Ben:** Ask about the ³ _____ through the appropriate process. We need enough relevant information to understand the request, not a public explanation of the employee's entire health history.
- 07 **Sana:** Would you handle any supporting health information? I do not want the employee to send it to a group mailbox that the whole department can open.
- 08 **Ben:** Yes, we will use the designated route for ⁴ _____. Any necessary supporting information should reach the authorized people under the applicable procedure, not become a general team update.
- 09 **Sana:** I will list the early tasks and check which genuinely require eight-thirty coverage. Some may be scheduled that way simply because that is our usual routine.
- 10 **Ben:** Clarify the ⁵ _____ and the actual coverage needs. Separate a real task requirement from a customary schedule before treating them as interchangeable.

The conversation, continued

E Conversations / turns 11-20

Continue with the word bank on page 55.

- 11 **Sana:** Could a different schedule or another arrangement address the difficulty? I want to leave room for options without promising one before we understand the need.
- 12 **Ben:** That is part of the ⁶ _____. An alternative has to address the relevant barrier; offering something unrelated does not become effective just because it sounds flexible.
- 13 **Sana:** The employee asked to begin on October seventh. Should I tell payroll or the scheduling team that date is already confirmed?
- 14 **Ben:** Not as an ⁷ _____. It is the requested start date. We should move the review forward promptly and keep the status clear rather than quietly turn the request into an approved instruction.
- 15 **Sana:** What if there is a need for something temporary while the review continues? I should not improvise a promise outside my authority.
- 16 **Ben:** Any ⁸ _____ needs the relevant authorization and clear terms. A temporary label does not remove the need to state what is approved, for whom, and for how long.
- 17 **Sana:** I will acknowledge the request today and explain your contact route. Can we agree on the next update so the employee knows this is moving forward?
- 18 **Ben:** Exactly. Communicate ⁹ _____ accurately. Also establish a contact point and update time so the employee is not left wondering whether the request has disappeared.
- 19 **Sana:** If a decision is eventually made, we need to explain it clearly and provide the applicable route for questions, rather than send a bare yes or no.
- 20 **Ben:** Include the supported ¹⁰ _____ through the proper process. For now, the accurate message is received, review being arranged, and no decision or temporary schedule confirmed yet.

06

ANSWERS / EXPLANATIONS: PAGE 96

1. accommodation request | 2. individualized assessment | 3. workplace barrier | 4. medical confidentiality | 5. essential functions | 6. interactive process | 7. implementation date | 8. interim arrangement | 9. request status | 10. decision rationale

Keep the requested date separate

F Say it

An employee requests a schedule change from Monday. HR has acknowledged it, but assessment and approval are pending. No interim arrangement exists.

Complete the four gaps. Use each bank entry once.

06

WORD + PHRASE BANK

pending / requested / approved / acknowledged

Manager: "Monday is the ¹ _____ start date."

HR: "The request has been ² _____."

Manager: "The assessment is still ³ _____."

HR: "No interim arrangement is ⁴ _____."

ANSWERS / EXPLANATIONS: PAGE 96

1. requested | 2. acknowledged | 3. pending | 4. approved

Rehearse with a fixed script

1. Read the corrected schedule-request dialogue. Keep the 9:30 start from October 7 as requested rather than approved.
2. Switch roles. Stress individualized review, relevant work information, and the designated confidential route.
3. Complete and check the transfer. Read each current status without turning acknowledgment into approval or a temporary arrangement.

WORKING ALONE

Read both roles, pausing for two seconds when the speaker changes. Repeat with the bank covered, then check any missed expressions.

Clarify the handoff before assigning blame

A Read the situation

Coach a manager to separate positions from work needs and define a testable handoff without inventing shared fault or agreement.

Manager Ken asks HR coach Daria for help with Rosa and Felix, who each say the other should own the weekly account reconciliation. Their role notes never assigned that recurring task. Ken proposes a two-week trial: Rosa assembles the inputs by Monday noon, Felix checks them by Tuesday 10:00, and Ken approves the result by Tuesday 15:00. The colleagues have not yet discussed or accepted the proposal. No misconduct allegation is supplied.

PEOPLE / Ken: Team manager | Daria: HR coach

A SHARED PROBLEM DOES NOT PROVE SHARED FAULT

A manager can clarify a work arrangement without deciding that both people were equally to blame. Distinguish the missing responsibility from the accusations. A facilitated task discussion may help here; it should not be treated as a substitute for the proper response to serious misconduct or protected complaints.

Briefing checks

Circle one answer in each item. Use the briefing.

1. What underlying gap is established?

A Ken already approved both completed reconciliations.

B The recurring task was never assigned in the role notes.

C Both colleagues signed the same clear ownership plan.

D A formal investigation proved equal misconduct.

2. Who would approve the result under Ken's proposal?

A Felix alone

B An unnamed client automatically

C Ken

D Rosa alone

3. What is the status of the two-week trial?

A Proposed, not yet discussed or accepted by the colleagues

B Already completed successfully

C A permanent policy accepted by everyone

D A disciplinary sanction already issued

[Answers and explanations: page 97.](#)

The vocabulary that does the work

B Find the words / 1 of 2

Read the definitions and say the common word combinations aloud.

task ownership

Responsibility for ensuring a defined task is carried through.

IN USE clarify task ownership

role ambiguity

Uncertainty about responsibilities or expectations.

IN USE reduce role ambiguity

position

A person's stated demand or preferred outcome in a disagreement.

IN USE distinguish a position

underlying interest

The need or concern behind a stated position.

IN USE identify underlying interests

facilitated discussion

A conversation guided to clarify issues and possible arrangements.

IN USE arrange a facilitated discussion

mediation

A structured process using an impartial third party to help parties seek agreement.

IN USE assess whether mediation is appropriate

ground rule

An agreed condition for how a discussion will proceed.

IN USE establish ground rules

active listening

Listening that checks meaning before responding.

IN USE use active listening

paraphrase

A restatement used to check understanding of another person's meaning.

IN USE offer a neutral paraphrase

reframing

Restating a conflict in terms that clarify the issue or shared work need.

IN USE use constructive reframing

common ground

A relevant aim or fact the parties share.

IN USE identify common ground

boundary

A stated limit on responsibility, conduct, or authority.

IN USE clarify the boundary

Precision check

The missing assignment is established; equal fault is not. Rosa preparing inputs, Felix checking, and Ken approving are three distinct responsibilities. A proposed sequence does not become a working agreement merely because it looks clear on paper.

The vocabulary that does the work

B Find the words / 2 of 2

Read the definitions and say the common word combinations aloud.

handoff

Transfer of work or information between responsible people.

IN USE define the handoff

handoff criterion

The condition a work item must meet before transfer.

IN USE agree handoff criteria

responsibility matrix

A record showing who performs, approves, or supports each task.

IN USE update the responsibility matrix

accountable owner

The person answerable for the defined result.

IN USE name the accountable owner

consulted party

Someone whose input is sought before a relevant decision or action.

IN USE identify consulted parties

escalation trigger

A stated condition requiring an issue to be referred.

IN USE define an escalation trigger

working agreement

An explicit arrangement about how people will coordinate work.

IN USE record a working agreement

trial period

A limited time for testing an arrangement.

IN USE set a trial period

review meeting

A planned discussion assessing the arrangement or progress.

IN USE schedule a review meeting

action log

A record of tasks, owners, dates, and status.

IN USE maintain an action log

coaching question

A question helping someone examine facts and choose a responsible action.

IN USE ask a coaching question

false equivalence

Treating unequal or unestablished conduct as if responsibility were the same.

IN USE avoid false equivalence

Precision check

A deadline needs a usable handoff criterion and a route for missing inputs. The trial should have a defined duration and review. Do not claim that both colleagues agreed before hearing and recording their actual responses.

Phrases you can actually use

C Notice the language / 1 of 2

START WITH THE KNOWN GAP

"The role notes do not assign the recurring reconciliation."

SEPARATE THE POSITIONS

"Each person says the other should own the task."

REFRAME THE ISSUE

"We need a reliable weekly handoff, not a contest over who cares more."

NAME THE DATES

"Inputs Monday noon, checks Tuesday 10:00, approval Tuesday 15:00."

AVOID A BLAME SHORTCUT

"We have not established that both people failed an agreed duty."

ASK ABOUT THE NEED

"What information or authority does each person need to complete their part?"

STATE THE PROPOSED SEQUENCE

"Rosa prepares inputs, Felix checks, and Ken approves."

DEFINE TRANSFER QUALITY

"Specify what complete inputs must contain before they are handed over."

Both

Do not use it to manufacture equal responsibility.

Help

Too vague unless the task and timing are named.

Own

Clarify doing, checking, approving, or overall accountability.

Phrases you can actually use

C Notice the language / 2 of 2

MAKE A BLOCKAGE VISIBLE

"A missing-input problem needs a named escalation route."

CHECK UNDERSTANDING

"Ask each colleague to restate their task and the handoff."

ASSIGN ACCOUNTABILITY

"Ken remains the named approver in this proposal."

USE THE APPROPRIATE PROCESS

"A task discussion does not replace formal handling of a serious complaint."

KEEP THE PROPOSAL HONEST

"The two-week trial has not yet been accepted."

PRESERVE A DISAGREEMENT

"Record any remaining objection instead of writing agreement prematurely."

LIMIT THE TRIAL

"Review the arrangement after two weekly cycles."

CLOSE WITH A RECORD

"Document the actual arrangement, owners, deadlines, and review point."

Agree

Requires actual assent to the stated arrangement.

Trial

A bounded test, not a permanent policy by implication.

Neutral

Fair process does not mean ignoring evidence of unequal conduct.

Choose the precise message

D Check your understanding

Circle one best answer for each item. Use the stated purpose and case facts, not the option that merely sounds most polite.

1. Which opening avoids an unsupported blame judgment?

- A** The reconciliation task was not assigned; let us clarify the required handoff.
- B** Both people are equally guilty by definition.
- C** One must be lazy because they disagree.
- D** The role notes prove a clear assignment to both.

07

2. Which addition would make the proposed Monday handoff more usable?

- A** Give Felix final approval authority even though Ken remains the proposed approver.
- B** Define the required input fields and a named route for reporting missing information before the handoff.
- C** State Monday noon again without identifying what Felix needs to receive.
- D** Mark the task agreed because Ken has drafted a sequence.

3. Which summary preserves the proposal's status?

- A** Ken proposes a two-week trial; the colleagues' responses are still needed.
- B** Everyone has accepted a permanent arrangement.
- C** The trial has passed two successful cycles.
- D** Neither colleague has any right to raise a practical concern.

4. Why is automatic equal blame inappropriate?

- A** Clarifying ownership requires finding both people guilty.
- B** The manager must ignore all evidence to stay neutral.
- C** The facts do not establish equivalent conduct or a previously assigned duty.
- D** Every disagreement always has exactly equal causes.

Answers and explanations: [page 97](#).

Clarify the handoff before assigning blame

E Conversations / turns 1-10

Complete the numbered gaps. Use each bank entry once, without changing its form. Cover the answers at the end until you finish.

WORD + PHRASE BANK

false equivalence / facilitated discussion / common ground / escalation trigger / working agreement / handoff criterion / role ambiguity / positions / trial period / responsibility matrix

07

- 01 **Ken:** Rosa and Felix each say the other should handle the weekly reconciliation. I was going to tell them both to stop blaming each other and cooperate.
- 02 **Daria:** First address the ¹ _____. The role notes never assigned this recurring task, so cooperation alone will not tell them who must prepare, check, or approve it.
- 03 **Ken:** That is true. Rosa says it belongs with Felix's reporting work, while Felix says Rosa has the client information and should own the whole task.
- 04 **Daria:** Those are their stated ² _____. Ask what each needs to do the work reliably, including information, timing, and authority, instead of treating either statement as the complete explanation.
- 05 **Ken:** They both want the reconciliation finished on time. Can we start there and agree on the work sequence instead of opening with another argument about attitude?
- 06 **Daria:** Use that ³ _____ to frame the discussion. It does not prove they agree about ownership, but it gives them a concrete result to organize the work around.
- 07 **Ken:** My proposal is for Rosa to assemble the inputs by Monday noon, Felix to check them by Tuesday ten, and me to approve by Tuesday fifteen hundred.
- 08 **Daria:** Put that in a ⁴ _____. Three named stages are clearer than saying both own it, provided the boundaries and resources are actually workable.
- 09 **Ken:** I also need to define what Rosa sends. Otherwise Felix may receive an incomplete file and the same conflict will reappear at the next stage.
- 10 **Daria:** Agree the ⁵ _____ for those inputs. A deadline is not enough if the receiver cannot tell whether the transferred work is complete and usable.

The conversation, continued

E Conversations / turns 11-20

Continue with the word bank on page 64.

- 11 **Ken:** What if information from a client is missing by Monday noon? I do not want the plan to hide a dependency neither colleague controls.
- 12 **Daria:** Define an ⁶ _____ and who receives it. That should expose the missing input early without implying either person can invent the information to satisfy the timetable.
- 13 **Ken:** I want to test this for two weeks and review the results. I should still hear their practical objections before writing that the arrangement is agreed.
- 14 **Daria:** Correct. A ⁷ _____ is a proposal until the relevant discussion and authorization occur. Record what is actually decided, including any point that remains unresolved.
- 15 **Ken:** I was going to ask both to apologize, but I cannot say they caused the problem equally. We never assigned the task clearly in the first place.
- 16 **Daria:** Avoid ⁸ _____. You can address any supported behavior separately without manufacturing equal blame simply to make the conversation look balanced.
- 17 **Ken:** Would a joint task discussion be appropriate here? There is no misconduct allegation in the information I have given you, just a recurring ownership dispute.
- 18 **Daria:** A ⁹ _____ may help clarify this work arrangement. If a different or serious concern emerges, use the relevant process rather than forcing every issue into an ownership compromise.
- 19 **Ken:** I will ask each person to restate the task, timing, and missing-input route. Then I can record the actual arrangement and review it after two cycles.
- 20 **Daria:** That produces a usable ¹⁰ _____ if the discussion supports it. Keep your approval responsibility explicit, and evaluate the trial against completed handoffs rather than the absence of visible disagreement.

07

ANSWERS / EXPLANATIONS: PAGE 98

1. role ambiguity | 2. positions | 3. common ground | 4. responsibility matrix | 5. handoff criterion | 6. escalation trigger | 7. trial period | 8. false equivalence | 9. facilitated discussion | 10. working agreement

Proposed is not agreed

F Say it

A manager proposes that Ana prepares a file Monday, Bo checks it Tuesday, and the manager approves it Wednesday. Neither colleague has yet responded.

Complete the four gaps. Use each bank entry once.

WORD + PHRASE BANK

prepare / pending / approval / check

HR: "Ana's proposed role is to ¹ _____ the file."

Manager: "Bo would ² _____ it on Tuesday."

HR: "The manager would give ³ _____ on Wednesday."

Manager: "The colleagues' responses remain ⁴ _____."

ANSWERS / EXPLANATIONS: PAGE 98

1. prepare | 2. check | 3. approval | 4. pending

Rehearse with a fixed script

1. Read turns 1-10. Distinguish the unassigned task from an established breach, then separate preparation, checking, and approval.

2. Switch roles for turns 11-20. Keep the two-week trial proposed until the colleagues' actual responses are recorded.

3. Complete and check the transfer. Read Ana's Monday preparation, Bo's Tuesday check, and the manager's Wednesday approval as proposed.

WORKING ALONE

Read both roles, pausing for two seconds when the speaker changes. Repeat with the bank covered, then check any missed expressions.

Do not call possible job losses small changes

A Read the situation

Communicate a restructuring proposal with empathy while separating confirmed facts, possible impacts, and unfinished decisions.

HR director Mei and communications lead Owen review a restructuring announcement. Twelve positions are within the proposal's review scope, but no final position-elimination count or individual outcome is confirmed. The draft says small changes and no one should worry. A Friday 11:00 staff update is scheduled; it is not a promised decision date. Mei wants a clear message that acknowledges potential employment consequences, explains what remains open, and points employees to an appropriate contact without inventing assurances.

PEOPLE / Mei: HR director | Owen: Communications lead

08

REASSURANCE SHOULD NOT ERASE THE STAKES

People may hear an upbeat phrase as evasive when their employment could be affected. Name the proposal and uncertainty plainly, acknowledge the impact, and offer a real contact and update. Avoid implying that an unfinished decision is final or that a genuine risk does not exist.

Briefing checks

Circle one answer in each item. Use the briefing.

1. What does the number twelve describe?

A The final severance payment

B A completed list of affected individuals

C Positions in the proposal's review scope

D Confirmed dismissals

2. What is confirmed for Friday at 11:00?

A Guaranteed confirmation that no jobs are affected

B Every employee's departure time

C A staff update

D A final decision on every position

3. Why is "small changes" unsuitable here?

A It accurately states a verified small impact.

B It gives the final position count.

C It identifies the complete consultation process.

D It minimizes possible employment consequences.

Answers and explanations: [page 99](#).

The vocabulary that does the work

B Find the words / 1 of 2

Read the definitions and say the common word combinations aloud.

restructuring

A change to how an organization arranges its work, roles, or reporting.

IN USE communicate a restructuring proposal

operating model

The arrangement through which an organization delivers its work.

IN USE review the operating model

business rationale

The stated business reason for a proposed change.

IN USE explain the business rationale

review scope

The roles, activities, or issues included in an assessment.

IN USE define the review scope

role impact

The effect of a change on a position's work or existence.

IN USE assess role impact

at-risk position

A position potentially affected, not necessarily finally eliminated.

IN USE clarify at-risk positions

position elimination

Removal of a defined role from the organizational structure.

IN USE distinguish position elimination

headcount

A count of people under a specified employment definition.

IN USE state the headcount basis

redeployment

Moving an employee into another suitable role under the relevant process.

IN USE explore redeployment

consultation

A process for seeking and considering relevant views under applicable arrangements.

IN USE conduct meaningful consultation

selection criteria

The defined basis for a relevant choice among roles or people.

IN USE explain selection criteria

individual notification

Communication to a particular person about their situation.

IN USE arrange individual notification

08

Precision check

Twelve positions in scope does not mean twelve people will leave. Roles, current incumbents, and final employment outcomes are different categories. Friday 11:00 is the next update; it is not evidence that all decisions will be complete then.

The vocabulary that does the work

B Find the words / 2 of 2

Read the definitions and say the common word combinations aloud.

notice period

The applicable interval between employment notice and its effective end.

IN USE confirm the notice period

severance

Separation-related pay or arrangements under applicable terms and rules.

IN USE explain severance terms

transition support

Assistance during a change in role or employment.

IN USE provide transition support

retention risk

The possibility of losing employees the organization seeks to retain.

IN USE assess retention risk

manager briefing

Information given to managers so they can communicate accurately.

IN USE prepare a manager briefing

talking points

Key statements supporting a consistent conversation.

IN USE approve talking points

message cascade

Planned communication through successive organizational levels.

IN USE coordinate the message cascade

rumor

Unverified information circulating informally.

IN USE address a rumor accurately

confirmed fact

Information established sufficiently for the stated communication.

IN USE distinguish confirmed facts

open question

An issue for which a supported answer is not yet available.

IN USE record open questions

employee assistance program

A workplace support service whose scope depends on the actual program.

IN USE explain the employee assistance program

change fatigue

Strain associated with repeated or prolonged organizational change.

IN USE acknowledge change fatigue

Precision check

Do not promise no job losses, guaranteed redeployment, or particular separation terms without authority and supporting facts. Consultation, notification, representation, notice, and benefit obligations vary. A communication exercise cannot establish which legal process applies to a real restructuring.

Phrases you can actually use

C Notice the language / 1 of 2

NAME THE PROPOSAL

"We are reviewing a restructuring proposal that may affect positions."

SEPARATE THE OUTCOME

"That is not a confirmed count of positions to be eliminated."

ACKNOWLEDGE THE STAKES

"I recognize that this uncertainty can be difficult for employees."

EXPLAIN WHAT IS MISSING

"We cannot yet give a supported final count."

STATE THE SCOPE

"Twelve positions are within the current review scope."

AVOID FALSE COMFORT

"We should not say no one will be affected when that is not known."

PRESERVE THE STATUS

"No final individual outcome is confirmed in this briefing."

DISTINGUISH THE EVENT

"Friday at 11:00 is the next staff update, not a promised decision date."

08

Small

Can minimize a serious personal consequence even if the organizational scope is limited.

May

Signals possibility, not a hidden confirmation of a final outcome.

In scope

Included in a review, not necessarily selected for elimination.

Phrases you can actually use

C Notice the language / 2 of 2

KEEP THE UPDATE

"We will communicate the current status even if questions remain open."

HANDLE A RUMOR

"We have not confirmed that claim and should not repeat it as a decision."

GIVE A CONTACT

"Name the appropriate route for individual questions."

INVITE RELEVANT QUESTIONS

"Record unanswered questions and assign follow-up ownership."

PREPARE MANAGERS

"Give managers the same confirmed facts and limits."

AVOID INVENTED BENEFITS

"Do not promise a package or redeployment option before its terms are established."

PROTECT PERSONAL INFORMATION

"Use the appropriate individual process for personal employment details."

CLOSE WITH HONESTY

"State what is known, what remains open, and when the next update will occur."

08

Consultation

Should not be described as open if the relevant choice is already irreversibly decided.

Support

Name the service and its actual scope; do not imply a guaranteed replacement job.

Update

A communication event that can report continuing uncertainty.

Choose the precise message

D Check your understanding

Circle one best answer for each item. Use the stated purpose and case facts, not the option that merely sounds most polite.

1. Which announcement keeps scope, employment outcome, and update timing separate?
 - A Final eliminations remain unconfirmed, but every individual outcome will be settled Friday 11:00.
 - B Twelve positions are under review; final changes are unconfirmed; Friday 11:00 is a status update.
 - C Twelve employees will leave, with their final decisions announced Friday 11:00.
 - D Twelve roles are under review, so exactly twelve redeployment places are guaranteed.

2. Which phrase offers empathy without an unsupported guarantee?
 - A Nobody has any reason to worry because all jobs are safe.
 - B Everyone will receive a guaranteed replacement role.
 - C This is too minor for questions.
 - D I recognize this uncertainty is difficult, and we will provide the next update Friday.

3. What should managers do with a rumor about a final list?
 - A Promise the opposite without evidence.
 - B Distinguish it from confirmed facts and use the authorized question route.
 - C Repeat it as a decision because several people heard it.
 - D Create an unofficial list from guesses.

4. If decisions remain open on Friday, what should the update say?
 - A State the current status, unresolved questions, and next contact arrangements.
 - B Pretend the review is complete to avoid discomfort.
 - C Cancel all future communication without explanation.
 - D Announce a random final number.

Answers and explanations: page 99.

Do not call possible job losses small changes

E Conversations / turns 1-10

Complete the numbered gaps. Use each bank entry once, without changing its form. Cover the answers at the end until you finish.

WORD + PHRASE BANK

redeployment / business rationale / consultation / confirmed fact / manager briefing / review
scope / open question / role impact / rumor / individual notification

08

- 01 **Owen:** The draft announcement calls this small changes and says no one should worry. I was trying to keep the tone calm, but those phrases may go too far.
- 02 **Mei:** They minimize the possible ¹ _____. People may face serious consequences, and we do not yet know the final outcome. Calm language still needs to acknowledge that.
- 03 **Owen:** We know that twelve positions are being examined. Some readers may assume that means twelve people have already been selected to leave.
- 04 **Mei:** Call it the ² _____. Twelve positions are within the proposal's assessment, but that is not a confirmed position-elimination count or an individual notification.
- 05 **Owen:** What approved explanation can we give for considering the change? The message needs a reason, but I should not invent a savings figure to fill the gap.
- 06 **Mei:** Use the approved ³ _____ when it is available. Do not invent savings, performance problems, or strategic reasons merely to make the announcement sound complete.
- 07 **Owen:** We also need to distinguish a proposal from a final decision. I do not want an unfinished process presented as though employees are hearing the outcome.
- 08 **Mei:** Correct. If ⁴ _____ is part of the applicable process, describe it accurately. The message must not suggest a choice is open when it has already been settled, or settled when it remains open.
- 09 **Owen:** Friday at eleven is booked for a staff update. I originally wrote that everyone would know their position then, which is more than we have agreed.
- 10 **Mei:** That is not a ⁵ _____. The appointment is an update, not a promised decision date. We must communicate the current status even if the review is unfinished.

The conversation, continued

E Conversations / turns 11-20

Continue with the word bank on page 73.

- 11 **Owen:** Managers are going to get questions before Friday. Can we give them the verified facts, open points, and contact route now so they do not improvise answers?
- 12 **Mei:** Prepare a ⁶ _____ with what is known, what remains open, and the contact route. It should help them acknowledge questions without improvising employment assurances.
- 13 **Owen:** There is already a rumor about a final list. Should the announcement deny it outright, even though we have not checked the specific claim?
- 14 **Mei:** Address the ⁷ _____ with the actual verified status. We should neither repeat an unconfirmed list nor promise the opposite just to counter it.
- 15 **Owen:** People may also ask about alternative roles or separation arrangements. It would be tempting to promise broad support now and work out the details later.
- 16 **Mei:** Do not promise guaranteed ⁸ _____ or a particular package. Explain only the support and process that are actually established, with the appropriate route for individual questions.
- 17 **Owen:** We should keep personal employment information out of the broad announcement. A general update should not become an accidental disclosure about a named person.
- 18 **Mei:** Use the appropriate ⁹ _____ process when there is an actual supported message for that person. Do not imply it has happened merely because the staff update is scheduled.
- 19 **Owen:** I will replace small changes with a clear description of the proposal and potential impact. The closing will acknowledge uncertainty and confirm Friday's update.
- 20 **Mei:** Also record each ¹⁰ _____ with a follow-up owner. Employees deserve a truthful account of what we know and a reliable next contact, even when we cannot yet supply the answer they most want.

08

ANSWERS / EXPLANATIONS: PAGE 100

1. role impact | 2. review scope | 3. business rationale | 4. consultation | 5. confirmed fact | 6. manager briefing | 7. rumor | 8. redeployment | 9. individual notification | 10. open question

Scope is not an outcome

F Say it

Eight positions are included in a proposal review. Final changes are not decided. A Wednesday 14:00 update is scheduled, with no guaranteed individual outcome then.

Complete the four gaps. Use each bank entry once.

WORD + PHRASE BANK

decided / update / scope / outcome

08

HR: "Eight positions are in the review ¹ _____."

Manager: "Final changes are not yet ² _____."

HR: "Wednesday at 14:00 is the next ³ _____."

Manager: "We cannot promise an individual ⁴ _____ then."

ANSWERS / EXPLANATIONS: PAGE 100

1. scope | 2. decided | 3. update | 4. outcome

Rehearse with a fixed script

1. Read the announcement discussion. Stress twelve positions in review scope, not twelve confirmed departures.
2. Switch roles for turns 11-20. Read the Friday 11:00 update commitment without promising a final list or redeployment.
3. Complete and check the transfer. Keep eight positions in scope and Wednesday's 14:00 update separate from individual outcomes.

WORKING ALONE

Read both roles, pausing for two seconds when the speaker changes. Repeat with the bank covered, then check any missed expressions.

The time record shows six hours the payslip does not

E More workplace conversations / 1-10

Acknowledge a pay discrepancy, explain a bounded calculation, and arrange prompt follow-up.

In this simplified US case, an employee covered by federal overtime rules and not exempt from them worked 46 hours in one workweek. Payroll has confirmed a \$24 regular hourly rate with no other pay elements affecting it. Only 40 hours at \$24 were paid. The employee and HR adviser discuss the missing gross amount; applicable correction deadlines and any additional requirements still need payroll review.

PEOPLE / Sam: Employee | Ada: HR adviser

Use each bank entry once, without changing its form. Answers follow turn 20.

09

WORD + PHRASE BANK

pay adjustment / overtime rate / Gross pay / audit trail / time record / off-cycle payment

- 01 **Sam:** My time record shows forty-six hours, but the payslip only includes forty. I need to know whether the extra six hours have been lost.
- 02 **Ada:** I am sorry this has happened. Let us link the approved ¹ _____ to this payslip and raise the discrepancy with payroll promptly.
- 03 **Sam:** My supervisor says the extra work was not approved in advance. Does that mean those hours can simply disappear from the record?
- 04 **Ada:** No. Record the hours actually worked. A question about prior authorization must not be used to erase time or withhold pay that is due.
- 05 **Sam:** Payroll confirmed my regular rate is twenty-four dollars. How much is missing in this example before taxes and other deductions?
- 06 **Ada:** For the stated case, the ² _____ is thirty-six dollars. Six unpaid overtime hours therefore account for two hundred sixteen dollars of gross pay.
- 07 **Sam:** So the full gross amount for that workweek should be nine hundred sixty plus two hundred sixteen, or eleven hundred seventy-six dollars?
- 08 **Ada:** Yes, on the facts supplied. ³ _____ is different from the amount deposited after the applicable deductions.
- 09 **Sam:** Could someone just call the difference a discretionary bonus? I would like the correction to show which hours were missing.
- 10 **Ada:** The ⁴ _____ needs the correct earnings description and record. Payroll should preserve the connection to this workweek and the original error.

The conversation, continued

E More workplace conversations / 11-20

Continue with the word bank on page 76.

- 11 **Sam:** When will I receive it? I have a bill due, and waiting until the next normal payday could be difficult.
- 12 **Ada:** I will flag the urgency and ask payroll for the required correction timing, including any ⁵ _____ arrangement. I cannot promise a payment date before they confirm it.
- 13 **Sam:** Please do not let the case close just because a ticket has been created. I need an answer I can plan around.
- 14 **Ada:** Agreed. I will give you a status update today and identify the owner. The case remains open until the correction and employee communication are resolved.
- 15 **Sam:** Do you need my full bank statement to check this? It contains unrelated transactions I would rather not share.
- 16 **Ada:** Do not send that unnecessarily. We will use the relevant payroll records and the designated secure route for any information actually needed.
- 17 **Sam:** I can check the corrected statement against the hours and amount once it is issued. Will the original entry remain traceable?
- 18 **Ada:** Yes. The ⁶ _____ should show what changed and why, including confirmation of the actual payment.
- 19 **Sam:** Thank you. Please send the case reference and today's update time so I know whom to contact if I hear nothing.
- 20 **Ada:** I will. We will address the missing pay promptly and keep any separate discussion about scheduling approval from obscuring the earnings issue.

09

ANSWERS / EXPLANATIONS: PAGE 101

1. time record | 2. overtime rate | 3. Gross pay | 4. pay adjustment | 5. off-cycle payment | 6. audit trail

A gross correction is mistaken for a promised deposit

F Say it in a new situation

Payroll confirms that a \$180 gross earnings correction is due. The final deductions and payment date have not yet been confirmed.

Complete the four gaps. Use each bank entry once.

WORD + PHRASE BANK

amount / payment / record / status

09

Adviser: The confirmed correction is a gross earnings ¹ _____.

Employee: Please confirm the payment date rather than just the ticket

² _____.

Adviser: Payroll must identify the applicable deductions and net

³ _____.

Employee: Keep the correction linked to the original pay ⁴ _____.

ANSWERS / EXPLANATIONS: PAGE 101

1. amount | 2. status | 3. payment | 4. record

Read, switch, repeat

1. Check the four answers and read the complete exchange aloud.

2. Switch roles. Read it again with the word bank covered.

3. Return to the extended conversation. Read turns 1-10, then switch roles for turns 11-20. Use the corrected expressions.

SOLO PRACTICE

Read both roles. Pause briefly at each change of speaker. Repeat any line that needed an answer check.

Selected for the role, but the transfer date is still open

E More workplace conversations / 1-10

Clarify an internal move without confusing selection, approved terms, and handover arrangements.

An internal candidate has been selected for a permanent analyst vacancy. The formal terms and transfer date have not been approved. The receiving manager proposes November 2, while the current manager requests a four-week handover. The recruiter and receiving manager must resolve the outstanding points without presenting either manager's preference as an agreed condition.

PEOPLE / Leah: Internal recruiter | Kofi: Receiving manager

Use each bank entry once, without changing its form. Answers follow turn 20.

10

WORD + PHRASE BANK

offer terms / selection decision / transition plan / confirmation / secondment / release date

- 01 **Kofi:** The panel selected Amira. I would like to announce that she joins us on November second so the team can start assigning work.
- 02 **Leah:** Please wait. The ¹ _____ is recorded, but the formal terms and transfer date are still open.
- 03 **Kofi:** I thought an internal move would be simpler than an external hire. Her current manager is now asking for a four-week handover.
- 04 **Leah:** That is a request to discuss, not an agreed ² _____. We need Amira and the relevant decision makers included in the timing conversation.
- 05 **Kofi:** The vacancy is permanent. Someone has started calling it a secondment because the start date is uncertain.
- 06 **Leah:** Correct that. A ³ _____ is a different arrangement. We should not change the nature of the role just to describe an unfinished handover.
- 07 **Kofi:** What is still needed on compensation? The role has a salary range, but I have not made an individual offer.
- 08 **Leah:** The approved ⁴ _____, including the relevant pay and conditions. Please do not let an informal conversation become a promise before that review is complete.
- 09 **Kofi:** Understood. Can I at least discuss the work she would take on and the training she would need?
- 10 **Leah:** Yes, explain the role accurately and hear her questions. Keep preparation distinct from assigning work under a transfer that has not taken effect.

The conversation, continued

E More workplace conversations / 11-20

Continue with the word bank on page 79.

- 11 **Kofi:** Her current team says only Amira knows one monthly report. I do not want the handover to become an indefinite reason to delay her.
- 12 **Leah:** Ask for a bounded ⁵ _____. Identify the report, a receiving owner, and practical training needs, then escalate unresolved timing through the applicable process.
- 13 **Kofi:** We should also avoid asking her to do both full roles for several weeks. That would hide the capacity problem rather than solve it.
- 14 **Leah:** Agreed. Make any overlap duties and limits explicit. The two managers need to resolve competing assignments instead of leaving Amira to negotiate them alone.
- 15 **Kofi:** Who should confirm the final arrangement to her? At the moment she has three different messages from us.
- 16 **Leah:** Let us coordinate one written ⁶ _____ once the relevant approvals and her response are complete. I will coordinate it and keep both managers informed.
- 17 **Kofi:** I will pause the announcement and send you the proposed first-month responsibilities. November second will stay a proposal for now.
- 18 **Leah:** Thank you. I will arrange the timing discussion and tell Amira what remains outstanding, with a clear date for the next update.
- 19 **Kofi:** When we do announce it, we should use the agreed title and date, not repeat the earlier secondment description.
- 20 **Leah:** Exactly. A clear internal move needs consistent terms, a workable handover, and the employee included in the decisions affecting the transition.

10

ANSWERS / EXPLANATIONS: PAGE 102

1. selection decision | 2. release date | 3. secondment | 4. offer terms | 5. transition plan | 6. confirmation

A manager announces a date the employee has not agreed

F Say it in a new situation

A manager proposes December 1 for an internal transfer. Formal terms and the employee's response are still outstanding.

Complete the four gaps. Use each bank entry once.

WORD + PHRASE BANK

agreed / discussion / approvals / terms

10

Recruiter: December first is proposed, not yet ¹ _____.

Manager: I will pause the announcement while we resolve the ² _____.

Recruiter: Include the employee in the transition ³ _____.

Manager: Send one accurate confirmation after the required ⁴ _____.

ANSWERS / EXPLANATIONS: PAGE 102

1. agreed | 2. terms | 3. discussion | 4. approvals

Read, switch, repeat

1. Check the four answers and read the complete exchange aloud.
2. Switch roles. Read it again with the word bank covered.
3. Return to the extended conversation. Read turns 1-10, then switch roles for turns 11-20. Use the corrected expressions.

SOLO PRACTICE

Read both roles. Pause briefly at each change of speaker. Repeat any line that needed an answer check.

Twelve employees do not equal twelve full-time equivalents

E More workplace conversations / 1-10

Explain workforce measures and reject unsupported conclusions about staffing capacity.

A department has eight employees scheduled for 40 hours a week and four scheduled for 20 hours. For this internal report, one full-time equivalent equals 40 scheduled weekly hours. Two additional positions are vacant. A draft shows 14 employees and 14 full-time equivalents. No skill coverage, absence, or productivity data is supplied.

PEOPLE / Ravi: People analyst | June: Department director

Use each bank entry once, without changing its form. Answers follow turn 20.

WORD + PHRASE BANK

vacancy / headcount / Actual hours / skills coverage / FTE / scheduled hours

11

- 01 **June:** The staffing slide says fourteen people and fourteen full-time equivalents. That sounds like enough coverage, but the team says we are stretched.
- 02 **Ravi:** The ¹ _____ is twelve. The two vacancies belong in a separate field because there are no employees occupying them.
- 03 **June:** Eight people work forty hours and four work twenty. Can you show how that becomes a capacity figure without losing the number of people?
- 04 **Ravi:** That is four hundred ² _____ a week: three hundred twenty from the eight full-time schedules and eighty from the four part-time schedules.
- 05 **June:** So four hundred divided by forty gives ten full-time equivalents. The four people on half-time schedules contribute two full-time equivalents, but they remain four people.
- 06 **Ravi:** Exactly. The ³ _____ is ten under this definition. I will correct the arithmetic and keep the basis beside the result.
- 07 **June:** Does the ten tell us how many productive hours the department actually delivered last week?
- 08 **Ravi:** No. This uses scheduled hours. ⁴ _____, absence, training, and the work performed would need their own data and definitions.
- 09 **June:** Then the slide should not claim that filling two vacancies automatically gives us twelve full-time equivalents either.
- 10 **Ravi:** Right. We need the approved hours for those positions before adding any projected capacity. A ⁵ _____ does not supply hours merely because it appears on the organization chart.

The conversation, continued

E More workplace conversations / 11-20

Continue with the word bank on page 82.

- 11 **June:** One of the open roles requires a specialist qualification. General additional hours would not necessarily cover that work.
- 12 **Ravi:** That is why the ⁶ _____ view matters alongside the total. Ten FTE does not mean every required task or shift is covered.
- 13 **June:** Can you split the report into employees, scheduled FTE, vacancies, and the outstanding capability questions?
- 14 **Ravi:** Yes. I will also give the reporting date and population so another department does not compare it with a month-average figure by mistake.
- 15 **June:** We use a different hours basis in one external return. Should we force this internal calculation into that form as well?
- 16 **Ravi:** No. Follow each report's applicable definition and explain the difference. A familiar label does not make two calculation methods interchangeable.
- 17 **June:** The corrected slide will therefore show twelve employees, ten scheduled FTE, and two vacancies with hours still to confirm.
- 18 **Ravi:** Correct. It will not infer a productivity result, a sufficient staffing level, or a hiring decision from those totals alone.
- 19 **June:** Please include the skill gap as an open question for our workforce review. That is the discussion the original fourteen-person headline obscured.
- 20 **Ravi:** I will. We can make the staffing decision clearer by keeping people, hours, vacant positions, and required capabilities visible separately.

11

ANSWERS / EXPLANATIONS: PAGE 103

1. headcount | 2. scheduled hours | 3. FTE | 4. Actual hours | 5. vacancy | 6. skills coverage

Three half-time roles are counted as three FTE

F Say it in a new situation

For this internal calculation, one FTE is 40 scheduled hours a week. Three employees each work 20 scheduled hours a week.

Complete the four gaps. Use each bank entry once.

WORD + PHRASE BANK

sixty / productivity / FTE / employees

Director: The headcount is three ¹ _____.

Analyst: Their scheduled weekly hours total ² _____.

Director: On a forty-hour basis, that gives one point five ³ _____.

Analyst: That figure alone does not establish actual ⁴ _____.

11

ANSWERS / EXPLANATIONS: PAGE 103

1. employees | 2. sixty | 3. FTE | 4. productivity

Read, switch, repeat

1. Check the four answers and read the complete exchange aloud.
2. Switch roles. Read it again with the word bank covered.
3. Return to the extended conversation. Read turns 1-10, then switch roles for turns 11-20. Use the corrected expressions.

SOLO PRACTICE

Read both roles. Pause briefly at each change of speaker. Repeat any line that needed an answer check.

01 Briefing and language checks

Recruiting, Screening, and Candidate Experience

A Briefing checks / page 4

1. Which tasks are actually required?

B. Client follow-up and escalation of conflicting deadlines

The brief identifies two work requirements, not a preferred personality or social background.

2. What is wrong with the draft scorecard?

A. It uses impressions without observable evidence criteria.

Confidence and shared interests do not explain how candidates will demonstrate the required tasks.

3. What is the current selection status?

D. No applicant has been scored.

The brief explicitly places this discussion before the panel scores applicants.

D Language checks / page 9

1. Which question best elicits behavioral evidence for the required escalation skill?

B. Tell us about a deadline conflict, what you escalated, and the result.

An actual past event, action, and result supplies behavioral evidence. The hypothetical question is job-related but situational, not evidence of what the applicant previously did.

2. A panelist says, "I liked their energy, so I scored follow-up highly." What is the best response?

D. Which example shows how they followed through on a client commitment?

The question redirects an impression toward evidence relevant to the competency being scored.

3. What belongs in a selection rationale?

B. Relevant evidence linked to the agreed criteria

A defensible explanation connects the observed response to the stated assessment standard.

4. Which candidate update is supported before selection?

C. We are completing interviews and will update you on the stated date.

A process update can be promised without falsely announcing a hiring outcome.

01 Conversation answers

Recruiting, Screening, and Candidate Experience

E Dialogue gaps

Pages 10-11

1. job-related competency. Turn 2. The competency must connect the preference to required work rather than social similarity.

2. role profile. Turn 4. The role profile defines the position's work before candidate preferences become assessment criteria.

3. behavioral question. Turn 6. A behavioral question asks for an actual past example, here involving conflicting client commitments.

4. scoring rubric. Turn 8. A scoring rubric supplies the common standards for judging responses before the panel scores candidates.

5. affinity bias. Turn 10. Affinity bias favors perceived similarity, such as shared interests, rather than evidence of relevant capability.

6. rating anchors. Turn 12. Rating anchors describe score levels so assessors can explain why particular evidence earns a rating.

7. structured interview. Turn 14. A structured interview uses common questions and standards while allowing appropriate access arrangements.

8. candidate experience. Turn 16. Candidate experience includes the clarity and reliability of recruitment communication, not just the interview itself.

9. selection rationale. Turn 18. The selection rationale links the decision to relevant evidence and agreed criteria rather than a vague impression.

10. Offer approval. Turn 20. Offer approval is authorization for proposed employment terms, separate from shortlisting or a positive interview.

F Transfer conversation

Page 12

1. evidence

Recruiter: "A shared hobby is not job-related evidence."

The hobby does not demonstrate the teamwork behavior the panel needs to assess.

2. criterion

Manager: "We need an example against the agreed criterion."

The assessment must refer to the stated teamwork requirement rather than personal similarity.

3. rationale

Recruiter: "The score needs a supported rationale."

A rating needs an explanation connected to actual relevant evidence.

4. approved

Manager: "No offer has been approved."

The supplied facts explicitly leave the hiring decision without approval.

02 Briefing and language checks

Onboarding and Role Clarity

A Briefing checks / page 13

1. What is already complete?

B. Equipment and account setup

The checklist covers setup tasks, not the employee's full readiness for independent work.

2. What is proposed for day ten?

B. Review five sample cases

The proposed first milestone is five sample cases checked against the stated requirements.

3. What must precede independent case ownership?

B. Nora's sign-off

The brief explicitly requires the manager's sign-off before independent ownership.

D Language checks / page 18

1. Which checklist status is accurate on day three?

D. System setup complete; role learning not yet complete

The completed tasks concern equipment and accounts, while role expectations remain to be agreed.

2. Which day-ten milestone combines quantity, timing, and an assessment basis?

D. Review five sample cases by day ten, checking required fields and the escalation route.

The first milestone checks the specified work and criteria. Access, an automatic authority claim, or reading alone does not satisfy the proposed case review.

3. What does the day-thirty meeting establish in advance?

D. A planned readiness assessment, not a guaranteed outcome

A scheduled review does not determine what the assessment will find.

4. How should Evan raise missing sample access?

B. I need access to the sample cases to meet the day-ten milestone.

This statement connects a specific missing resource to the agreed work and date.

02 Conversation answers

Onboarding and Role Clarity

E Dialogue gaps

Pages 19-20

- 1. access provisioning.** Turn 2. Access provisioning establishes working accounts and permissions, not readiness for the whole role.
- 2. first-month plan.** Turn 4. The first-month plan puts the proposed learning tasks and review points into a clear sequence.
- 3. success criteria.** Turn 6. Success criteria specify required fields and the escalation route, not just the number of completed cases.
- 4. escalation route.** Turn 8. The escalation route identifies where Evan should refer uncertainty beyond the scope of his current responsibility.
- 5. shadowing.** Turn 10. Shadowing means observing an experienced colleague at work before or alongside practice.
- 6. decision authority.** Turn 12. Decision authority distinguishes who can approve work from a colleague who provides informal guidance.
- 7. readiness review.** Turn 14. The readiness review assesses preparedness on day thirty without guaranteeing independent ownership then.
- 8. sign-off.** Turn 16. Sign-off is the explicit manager approval required before Evan takes independent ownership.
- 9. dependency.** Turn 18. The missing sample folder is a resource needed to complete the first milestone.
- 10. role clarity.** Turn 20. Role clarity makes the responsibilities, sequence, support, and authority understandable to both parties.

F Transfer conversation

Page 21

1. complete

Employee: "Account setup is complete."

Monday's finished setup supports that status only for the accounts.

2. sample

Manager: "The next milestone is three sample cases."

The briefing identifies three sample cases as the next defined task.

3. review

Employee: "Independent processing still requires a review."

The supplied condition requires a supervisor assessment before independent processing.

4. confirmed

Manager: "That approval is not yet confirmed."

The required review has not occurred, so approval cannot be reported as confirmed.

03 Briefing and language checks

Performance Feedback and Documentation

A Briefing checks / page 22

1. What was missing from the two reports?

C. The agreed summary section

The brief identifies one omitted section in each report, not wholesale failure of the work.

2. What does the draft note wrongly assume?

C. A motive and personality judgment not established by the facts

Careless and unmotivated go beyond the observed omissions and imply unsupported explanations.

3. What is the current meeting status?

D. Feedback without a formal disciplinary decision

The brief explicitly states that no formal warning or disciplinary decision has been made.

D Language checks / page 27

1. Which opening is most precise?

A. The September 11 and 18 reports omitted the required summary.

Two dated examples support a specific completeness concern, not a universal character judgment.

2. Which note preserves the distinction between an account and a verified cause?

C. Daniel said he used an older template; comparison with the current file is pending.

The employee has supplied an explanation, not a completed document comparison. Acknowledging an omission neither proves its cause nor admits a motive.

3. Which objective is measurable?

B. Include the required summary in the September 25 report and check it against the agreed template.

The objective identifies the work, required feature, date, and review basis.

4. What does a receipt acknowledgment alone establish?

D. The note was received

Receipt is a communication fact and should not be treated as agreement or a disciplinary outcome.

03 Conversation answers

Performance Feedback and Documentation

03

E Dialogue gaps

Pages 28-29

1. performance gap. Turn 2. The performance gap is the missing required summary, not a judgment about Daniel's character.

2. impact statement. Turn 4. The impact statement explains the extra request and delayed review caused by the omission.

3. employee response. Turn 6. The employee response is Daniel's explanation, which the manager can record and check.

4. factual record. Turn 8. A factual record separates the observed omissions from unsupported motive judgments and unverified explanations.

5. performance standard. Turn 10. The performance standard specifies the summary and supporting tables required in the next report.

6. support commitment. Turn 12. The support commitment is the manager's specific promise to provide and clarify the current template.

7. measurable objective. Turn 14. The measurable objective is a complete September 25 report checked against the specified template.

8. informal coaching. Turn 16. Informal coaching describes the stated feedback stage rather than inventing a formal disciplinary outcome.

9. acknowledgment of receipt. Turn 18. Acknowledgment of receipt confirms the note arrived without automatically agreeing to every statement.

10. follow-up evidence. Turn 20. Follow-up evidence is the next report assessed against the agreed completeness standard.

F Transfer conversation

Page 30

1. codes

Manager: "Two timesheets omitted the project codes."

The observable issue is the missing codes in two specified records.

2. unavailable

Employee: "My explanation is that the list was unavailable."

The supplied employee account identifies unavailable information as the reported barrier.

3. verified

Manager: "That explanation still needs to be verified."

The briefing explicitly says the reported cause has not yet been checked.

4. Friday

Employee: "The corrected next timesheet is due Friday."

The stated next deadline is Friday, not an unspecified future improvement date.



04 Briefing and language checks

Employee Relations and Investigations

04

A Briefing checks / page 31

1. What evidence is available at the start?

B. Tomas's initial account

The brief supplies one account while documents and possible witness information remain unchecked.

2. What is Imani's role in this conversation?

B. Receive and clarify the concern

This is an intake conversation, not a completed investigation or outcome meeting.

3. What is known about the possible witness?

B. Tomas thinks someone may have heard the comment.

Possible witness knowledge is reported but has not been established by a direct account.

D Language checks / page 36

1. Which intake note is most accurate?

A. Tomas reported exclusion from two meetings; invitations have not yet been reviewed.

The note attributes the report and preserves the missing-evidence status without prejudging the case.

2. Which question avoids adding facts to the September 15 account?

C. Where did the comment occur, who was present, and which words do you recall?

The brief dates the comment but does not place it at a meeting or establish intent, corroboration, or misconduct. The neutral question asks for those details without assuming them.

3. What is the best response to a request for total secrecy?

A. Explain careful handling and the limits of necessary, appropriate sharing.

Honest limits allow appropriate review without making a promise the adviser may be unable to keep.

4. What does a temporary separation arrangement establish by itself?

C. A temporary process measure, not a finding of guilt

An interim measure manages the situation while the assessment remains separate.

04 Conversation answers

Employee Relations and Investigations

E Dialogue gaps

Pages 37-38

- 1. intake.** Turn 2. Intake is the initial receipt and clarification of the concern, not a decision about its outcome.
- 2. chronology.** Turn 4. A chronology places the meetings and comment in time order so the account can be examined accurately.
- 3. firsthand account.** Turn 6. A firsthand account concerns what Tomas directly heard, unlike his inference about why invitations were missing.
- 4. witness.** Turn 8. The colleague is only a possible witness because their presence and knowledge have not yet been checked.
- 5. confidentiality.** Turn 10. Confidentiality involves careful information handling, not a guarantee that no appropriate person will need access.
- 6. need-to-know basis.** Turn 12. A need-to-know basis limits sharing to legitimate process needs rather than general workplace circulation.
- 7. allegation.** Turn 14. An allegation is a claim requiring assessment; the intake does not establish a disciplinary outcome.
- 8. evidence preservation.** Turn 16. Evidence preservation keeps relevant original messages and records available without changing them to fit an account.
- 9. retaliation concern.** Turn 18. A retaliation concern should be raised and assessed, not dismissed or automatically treated as a proven legal violation.
- 10. case update.** Turn 20. A case update reports process status without promising that the review will be finished or a particular result reached.

F Transfer conversation

Page 39

1. account

Adviser: "The note records the employee's account."

The note attributes the information to the person who supplied it.

2. contacted

Manager: "The possible witness has not yet been contacted."

The briefing says the witness has not been approached for information.

3. finding

Adviser: "The review has not produced a finding."

The current record contains a report, not an assessed conclusion.

4. update

Manager: "Tuesday is the promised status update."

The promised event is communication about progress, not a guaranteed outcome.

04

05 Briefing and language checks

Compensation, Benefits, and Equity

A Briefing checks / page 40

1. What is the range midpoint?

C. USD 80,000

The midpoint is the average of the 60,000 minimum and 100,000 maximum.

2. What does the fictional policy say about midpoint placement?

B. It is not automatic.

The supplied policy lists placement criteria and expressly rejects an automatic midpoint entitlement.

3. What is the status of the 5% target bonus?

C. Conditional, not guaranteed

The brief distinguishes the target bonus from base pay and says its payment is conditional.

D Language checks / page 45

1. What is Alex's compa-ratio?

B. 90%

Dividing the 72,000 base salary by the 80,000 midpoint gives 0.90, or 90%.

2. What does 30% represent here?

C. Salary position across the 60,000-100,000 interval

The salary is 12,000 above the minimum across a 40,000 range width, giving 30%.

3. Which statement handles the fairness question properly?

C. The range calculation does not replace review of your individual concern.

Numerical position alone neither resolves the concern nor establishes a legal conclusion.

4. Alex adds the conditional bonus to base and divides 75,600 by 80,000. What is wrong with calling 94.5% the base-pay compa-ratio?

A. That numerator includes a target incentive; the stated base-pay ratio remains 72,000 / 80,000 = 90%.

The 94.5% arithmetic is correct for that different numerator, but the defined compa-ratio compares base salary with midpoint. Range penetration uses a separate formula.

05 Conversation answers

Compensation, Benefits, and Equity

E Dialogue gaps

Pages 46-47

- 1. base salary.** Turn 2. Base salary is the fixed annual pay being compared with the range, excluding the conditional bonus.
- 2. midpoint.** Turn 4. The midpoint is the central range reference, 80,000 dollars, not an automatic individual salary under this policy.
- 3. compa-ratio.** Turn 6. Compa-ratio divides 72,000 base salary by the 80,000 midpoint, producing 90%.
- 4. range penetration.** Turn 8. Range penetration measures 12,000 above minimum across a 40,000 range width, producing 30%.
- 5. compensation review.** Turn 10. The compensation review examines individual placement under the stated criteria rather than inferring fairness from one ratio.
- 6. internal equity.** Turn 12. Internal equity concerns consistent and fair pay relationships, requiring relevant comparison rather than an unsupported individual conclusion.
- 7. target bonus.** Turn 14. The target bonus is conditional, so the calculated 3,600 amount cannot be treated as guaranteed payment.
- 8. variable pay.** Turn 16. Variable pay depends on specified conditions and must be distinguished from fixed base salary.
- 9. total rewards.** Turn 18. Total rewards includes benefits and other employment value beyond base salary and cash incentives.
- 10. pay disparity.** Turn 20. A pay disparity is a difference to examine with relevant facts, not automatically proof of an unlawful decision.

F Transfer conversation

Page 48

1. ninety

Employee: "My compa-ratio is ninety percent."

Dividing 54,000 by the 60,000 midpoint gives ninety percent.

2. dollars

HR: "The target bonus is 5,400 dollars."

Ten percent of the 54,000 base produces a 5,400-dollar target amount.

3. guaranteed

Employee: "That target is not guaranteed."

The briefing describes a conditional incentive, not a guaranteed payout.

4. unconfirmed

HR: "The actual payout remains unconfirmed."

No actual payment has been confirmed in the supplied facts.

05

06 Briefing and language checks

Policy Communication and Compliance

A Briefing checks / page 49

1. What change has the employee requested?

C. A 9:30 start instead of 8:30 from October 7

The briefing states a requested schedule change, not a broader employment decision.

2. What is the current status?

D. Received but not yet reviewed or decided

HR has not reviewed the request and no arrangement has been approved.

3. Which information still needs appropriate clarification?

A. The work barrier and relevant coverage implications

The brief identifies work-related questions while sensitive information requires appropriate handling.

D Language checks / page 54

1. Which first response is appropriate?

B. Acknowledge receipt and arrange the relevant discussion without promising the outcome.

The response is prompt and useful while preserving the need for an appropriate individual assessment.

2. How should October 7 be described now?

B. The requested start date

The employee requested that date, but the relevant decision has not been made.

3. Which information request respects the stated boundary?

B. Clarify the work barrier and use the designated route for any necessary sensitive support.

Relevant work questions and appropriately handled supporting information avoid unnecessary disclosure.

4. HR proposes a different arrangement from the requested 9:30 start. What needs checking?

A. Whether it addresses the actual barrier while meeting the relevant work requirements under the applicable process.

An alternative must be assessed for effectiveness in the individual circumstances; its label, popularity, or similarity to the standard schedule cannot establish that.

06 Conversation answers

Policy Communication and Compliance

E Dialogue gaps

Pages 55-56

- 1. accommodation request.** Turn 2. The accommodation request starts a relevant review; receipt alone does not decide the arrangement.
- 2. individualized assessment.** Turn 4. An individualized assessment considers the particular need and work circumstances rather than applying a blanket answer.
- 3. workplace barrier.** Turn 6. The workplace barrier is the relevant difficulty the requested schedule is intended to address.
- 4. medical confidentiality.** Turn 8. Medical confidentiality requires appropriate handling of sensitive information, separate from ordinary team circulation.
- 5. essential functions.** Turn 10. Essential functions are the fundamental duties that help frame the work assessment, not every customary scheduling preference.
- 6. interactive process.** Turn 12. The interactive process clarifies needs and explores effective options through discussion, not a predetermined outcome.
- 7. implementation date.** Turn 14. An implementation date belongs to an authorized arrangement; October 7 remains only the requested date here.
- 8. interim arrangement.** Turn 16. An interim arrangement is a temporary measure that still needs appropriate authority and clearly stated terms.
- 9. request status.** Turn 18. Request status names the current process stage, here received and awaiting review, rather than an invented outcome.
- 10. decision rationale.** Turn 20. The decision rationale explains the authorized outcome based on the review, not an assumption made at intake.

F Transfer conversation

Page 57

1. requested

Manager: "Monday is the requested start date."

The employee asked for Monday, but the arrangement has not been authorized.

2. acknowledged

HR: "The request has been acknowledged."

HR has confirmed receipt without deciding the substance of the request.

3. pending

Manager: "The assessment is still pending."

The briefing states that the review is not yet complete.

4. approved

HR: "No interim arrangement is approved."

No temporary arrangement exists under the supplied facts.

07 Briefing and language checks

Conflict Mediation and Manager Coaching

A Briefing checks / page 58

1. What underlying gap is established?

B. The recurring task was never assigned in the role notes.

The brief identifies an undocumented responsibility, not a proven refusal to follow an agreed assignment.

2. Who would approve the result under Ken's proposal?

C. Ken

The proposed sequence names Ken as the approver by Tuesday 15:00.

3. What is the status of the two-week trial?

A. Proposed, not yet discussed or accepted by the colleagues

The briefing expressly states that the colleagues have not yet discussed or accepted the proposal.

D Language checks / page 63

1. Which opening avoids an unsupported blame judgment?

A. The reconciliation task was not assigned; let us clarify the required handoff.

The opening uses the established documentation gap instead of assuming motive or equal fault.

2. Which addition would make the proposed Monday handoff more usable?

B. Define the required input fields and a named route for reporting missing information before the handoff.

A handoff needs a content standard and a way to surface blockages. Repeating the time does not supply either, and the proposal does not establish acceptance or different approval rights.

3. Which summary preserves the proposal's status?

A. Ken proposes a two-week trial; the colleagues' responses are still needed.

The supplied facts establish a proposal, not acceptance or evidence of successful operation.

4. Why is automatic equal blame inappropriate?

C. The facts do not establish equivalent conduct or a previously assigned duty.

Fair handling follows the evidence rather than forcing an equal-fault conclusion.

07 Conversation answers

Conflict Mediation and Manager Coaching

E Dialogue gaps

Pages 64-65

1. role ambiguity. Turn 2. Role ambiguity is the missing assignment in the role notes, which must be clarified before assuming a breached duty.

2. positions. Turn 4. Positions are the competing claims about ownership; the underlying practical needs may be different.

3. common ground. Turn 6. Common ground is the shared need for a reliable, timely reconciliation rather than assumed agreement on responsibility.

4. responsibility matrix. Turn 8. A responsibility matrix distinguishes preparing, checking, and approving instead of assigning vague shared ownership.

5. handoff criterion. Turn 10. The handoff criterion specifies what complete inputs must contain before Felix receives the work.

6. escalation trigger. Turn 12. An escalation trigger makes a missing-input problem visible through a stated referral point instead of silent delay.

7. trial period. Turn 14. A trial period limits the proposed arrangement to two weeks and creates a defined opportunity to assess it.

8. false equivalence. Turn 16. False equivalence would assign equal fault without evidence of equal conduct or an agreed prior responsibility.

9. facilitated discussion. Turn 18. A facilitated discussion can clarify the stated task dispute but is not a substitute for appropriate handling of other serious concerns.

10. working agreement. Turn 20. A working agreement records the actual coordination arrangement, not a proposal falsely described as accepted.

F Transfer conversation

Page 66

1. prepare

HR: "Ana's proposed role is to prepare the file."

The proposal assigns Ana the preparation stage rather than checking or approval.

2. check

Manager: "Bo would check it on Tuesday."

The stated second stage is Bo's Tuesday check.

3. approval

HR: "The manager would give approval on Wednesday."

The proposal reserves the final approval stage for the manager.

4. pending

Manager: "The colleagues' responses remain pending."

Neither colleague has responded, so their acceptance cannot yet be reported.

08 Briefing and language checks

Restructuring and Sensitive Communication

A Briefing checks / page 67

1. What does the number twelve describe?

C. Positions in the proposal's review scope

The brief defines a review scope, not a final count of eliminated roles or individual outcomes.

2. What is confirmed for Friday at 11:00?

C. A staff update

The scheduled event is a communication update, explicitly not a promised decision deadline.

3. Why is "small changes" unsuitable here?

D. It minimizes possible employment consequences.

The draft minimizes a potentially serious effect that has not yet been determined.

D Language checks / page 72

1. Which announcement keeps scope, employment outcome, and update timing separate?

B. Twelve positions are under review; final changes are unconfirmed; Friday 11:00 is a status update.

The case confirms the review scope and an update, not an elimination count, replacement roles, or a completed-decision date.

2. Which phrase offers empathy without an unsupported guarantee?

D. I recognize this uncertainty is difficult, and we will provide the next update Friday.

The statement acknowledges the stakes and promises a real communication event without inventing job security.

3. What should managers do with a rumor about a final list?

B. Distinguish it from confirmed facts and use the authorized question route.

Repetition does not verify a rumor, and unsupported counter-assurances are equally unreliable.

4. If decisions remain open on Friday, what should the update say?

A. State the current status, unresolved questions, and next contact arrangements.

The promised update can honestly report continuing uncertainty while keeping follow-up concrete.

08 Conversation answers

Restructuring and Sensitive Communication

E Dialogue gaps

Pages 73-74

1. role impact. Turn 2. Role impact includes potential changes to positions or employment, which the draft should not trivialize.

2. review scope. Turn 4. Review scope identifies the twelve positions being assessed, not a final elimination count or individual decision.

3. business rationale. Turn 6. The business rationale explains the reason for the proposal but must come from actual approved information.

4. consultation. Turn 8. Consultation involves seeking and considering views under the applicable process, not disguising a completed choice as open.

5. confirmed fact. Turn 10. The confirmed fact is the scheduled update, not a promise that all individual decisions will be ready.

6. manager briefing. Turn 12. A manager briefing gives leaders the same established facts, uncertainty boundaries, and contact routes.

7. rumor. Turn 14. A rumor is unverified information and should not become a confirmed decision through repetition or unsupported denial.

8. redeployment. Turn 16. Redeployment concerns another suitable role under the relevant process and cannot be guaranteed without established options.

9. individual notification. Turn 18. Individual notification addresses a particular person's situation through the proper process rather than a general announcement.

10. open question. Turn 20. Open questions remain visibly unanswered with follow-up ownership instead of being filled by invented assurances.

F Transfer conversation

Page 75

1. scope

HR: "Eight positions are in the review scope."

The number describes positions included in assessment, not a final elimination count.

2. decided

Manager: "Final changes are not yet decided."

The supplied facts leave the final outcome open.

3. update

HR: "Wednesday at 14:00 is the next update."

The scheduled event is communication about status rather than a guaranteed decision.

4. outcome

Manager: "We cannot promise an individual outcome then."

No individual decision has been guaranteed for that appointment.

08

09 Conversation answers

The time record shows six hours the payslip does not

E Extended conversation

Pages 76-77

1. time record. Turn 2. The time record provides the hours actually worked in the relevant workweek and is compared with the payroll entry.

2. overtime rate. Turn 6. The overtime rate in this case is one and one-half times the confirmed \$24 regular rate, or \$36 per overtime hour.

3. Gross pay. Turn 8. Gross pay is the amount before deductions; the calculated \$1,176 is not a promise of the same amount being deposited.

4. pay adjustment. Turn 10. The pay adjustment should accurately correct the missing earnings and their basis, rather than disguise them under an unrelated payment label.

5. off-cycle payment. Turn 12. An off-cycle payment is processed outside the normal payroll run; its availability and timing need confirmation rather than a casual promise.

6. audit trail. Turn 18. The audit trail connects the original entry, identified error, correction, and resulting payment without silently rewriting the earlier record.

F Transfer exchange

Page 78

1. amount

Adviser: The confirmed correction is a gross earnings amount.

Gross earnings are stated before deductions and do not establish the exact deposit.

2. status

Employee: Please confirm the payment date rather than just the ticket status.

An open ticket does not tell the employee when the money will actually be paid.

3. payment

Adviser: Payroll must identify the applicable deductions and net payment.

The net payment reflects the relevant deductions rather than automatically matching the gross correction.

4. record

Employee: Keep the correction linked to the original pay record.

The original record and correction should remain connected in the audit trail.

09

Background reading: [US Department of Labor: Overtime Pay](#). The conversation is an original fictional teaching case.

10 Conversation answers

Selected for the role, but the transfer date is still open

E Extended conversation

Pages 79-80

1. selection decision. Turn 2. The selection decision identifies the preferred candidate; it does not by itself establish approved terms or an agreed transfer date.

2. release date. Turn 4. The release date identifies the agreed transition out of the current role; a manager's preferred timing does not establish it unilaterally here.

3. secondment. Turn 6. A secondment is a temporary assignment with its own terms; uncertainty about timing does not convert a permanent move into one.

4. offer terms. Turn 8. Offer terms specify the actual employment or assignment conditions being offered, rather than only the role's general salary range.

5. transition plan. Turn 12. A transition plan identifies the work, knowledge transfer, owners, and timing needed for the move rather than leaving release indefinitely undefined.

6. confirmation. Turn 16. Confirmation communicates the actual agreed terms and effective date; it should replace conflicting informal messages without inventing an outcome.

F Transfer exchange

Page 81

1. agreed

Recruiter: December first is proposed, not yet agreed.

The supplied facts establish a suggested date rather than a completed agreement.

2. terms

Manager: I will pause the announcement while we resolve the terms.

Outstanding formal terms must not be hidden by announcing a settled move.

3. discussion

Recruiter: Include the employee in the transition discussion.

The employee should be involved rather than receiving conflicting decisions from separate managers.

4. approvals

Manager: Send one accurate confirmation after the required approvals.

The final communication should reflect actual approvals and the agreed position.

10

Background reading: [EEOC: Recruiting, Hiring, and Promoting Employees](#). The conversation is an original fictional teaching case.

11 Conversation answers

Twelve employees do not equal twelve full-time equivalents

E Extended conversation

Pages 82-83

1. headcount. Turn 2. Headcount counts people in the defined population; the department has twelve employees, while its two vacancies are not employees.

2. scheduled hours. Turn 4. Scheduled hours total the planned weekly hours: eight times forty plus four times twenty equals four hundred.

3. FTE. Turn 6. FTE means full-time equivalent; four hundred scheduled hours divided by the stated forty-hour basis gives ten FTE.

4. Actual hours. Turn 8. Actual hours describe recorded time for the specified period and are different from the scheduled-hours basis used in this example.

5. vacancy. Turn 10. A vacancy is an unfilled position, not an existing employee or a confirmed amount of staffed capacity.

6. skills coverage. Turn 12. Skills coverage considers whether the required capabilities are available, which an aggregate FTE figure cannot establish on its own.

F Transfer exchange

Page 84

1. employees

Director: The headcount is three employees.

Headcount counts the three people rather than converting them into full-time units.

2. sixty

Analyst: Their scheduled weekly hours total sixty.

Three employees multiplied by twenty hours equals sixty scheduled hours.

3. FTE

Director: On a forty-hour basis, that gives one point five FTE.

Sixty divided by forty equals one and one-half full-time equivalents.

4. productivity

Analyst: That figure alone does not establish actual productivity.

A scheduled-hours measure does not show how much useful work was actually completed.

Find the move you need

Use these as precise language models. Replace details only when you know the actual facts, authority, and agreed conditions.

01 Recruiting, Screening, and Candidate Experience

Clarify the preference: What specific work behavior do you mean by good fit?

Ask for evidence: Tell us about a time you handled two conflicting deadlines.

Keep comparison consistent: Use the same core questions and rating standards.

Full phrase set: pages 7-8 | Dialogue: pages 10-11

02 Onboarding and Role Clarity

Distinguish setup: My accounts work, but the role priorities are not yet clear.

Define the check: We will check the required fields and the escalation route.

Keep support visible: Bring unresolved cases to the named supervisor.

Full phrase set: pages 16-17 | Dialogue: pages 19-20

03 Performance Feedback and Documentation

Open with the work: I want to discuss the September 11 and 18 reports.

Invite context: Please walk me through how you prepared those reports.

Keep the standard clear: The September 25 report needs the summary section.

Full phrase set: pages 25-26 | Dialogue: pages 28-29

04 Employee Relations and Investigations

Acknowledge the concern: Thank you for bringing this to me.

Separate recollection: Are those the exact words you remember, or a summary?

Avoid prejudgment: I cannot determine the outcome from this conversation alone.

Full phrase set: pages 34-35 | Dialogue: pages 37-38

Keep the conversation productive

Use these as precise language models. Replace details only when you know the actual facts, authority, and agreed conditions.

05 Compensation, Benefits, and Equity

Acknowledge the question: I understand why the published midpoint prompted your question.

Calculate the center: The midpoint is 80,000 dollars.

Avoid a percentage mix-up: Thirty percent is range penetration, not the compa-ratio.

Full phrase set: pages 43-44 | Dialogue: pages 46-47

06 Policy Communication and Compliance

Acknowledge promptly: We have received your request and will arrange the appropriate discussion.

Separate dates: October 7 is the requested start date, not a confirmed implementation date.

Identify the work need: We need a clear description of the relevant coverage requirements.

Full phrase set: pages 52-53 | Dialogue: pages 55-56

07 Conflict Mediation and Manager Coaching

Start with the known gap: The role notes do not assign the recurring reconciliation.

Ask about the need: What information or authority does each person need to complete their part?

Define transfer quality: Specify what complete inputs must contain before they are handed over.

Full phrase set: pages 61-62 | Dialogue: pages 64-65

08 Restructuring and Sensitive Communication

Name the proposal: We are reviewing a restructuring proposal that may affect positions.

Avoid false comfort: We should not say no one will be affected when that is not known.

Distinguish the event: Friday at 11:00 is the next staff update, not a promised decision date.

Full phrase set: pages 70-71 | Dialogue: pages 73-74

Find a term and its context

The page number leads to the definition and a typical word combination. Repeated terms have separate entries when they serve different lesson contexts.

access provisioning	confirm access provisioning	14
accommodation request	acknowledge an accommodation request	50
accountable owner	name the accountable owner	60
acknowledgment of receipt	obtain acknowledgment of receipt	24
action log	maintain an action log	60
active listening	use active listening	59
affinity bias	challenge affinity bias	6
allegation	record an allegation	32
alternative arrangement	explore an alternative arrangement	50
at-risk position	clarify at-risk positions	68
attribution	check the attribution	23
barrier	explore a work barrier	23
base salary	state the annual base salary	41
behavioral evidence	request behavioral evidence	5
behavioral question	ask a behavioral question	5
benefits eligibility	confirm benefits eligibility	42
boundary	clarify the boundary	59
buddy	assign an onboarding buddy	15
business rationale	explain the business rationale	68
calibration	hold a calibration discussion	6
calibration meeting	prepare for a calibration meeting	24
candidate experience	improve the candidate experience	6
candidate pipeline	review the candidate pipeline	6
case update	provide a case update	33

Find a term and its context

The page number leads to the definition and a typical word combination. Repeated terms have separate entries when they serve different lesson contexts.

change fatigue acknowledge change fatigue	69
check-in hold a weekly check-in	15
chronology establish the chronology	32
coaching question ask a coaching question	60
common ground identify common ground	59
compa-ratio calculate the compa-ratio	41
compensation review request a compensation review	42
complainant contact the complainant	32
confidentiality explain confidentiality limits	33
confirmed fact distinguish confirmed facts	69
conflict of interest disclose a conflict of interest	33
consultation conduct meaningful consultation	68
consulted party identify consulted parties	60
contemporaneous note keep a contemporaneous note	24
contemporaneous record preserve contemporaneous records	32
corroboration seek corroboration	32
coverage requirement clarify coverage requirements	50
data minimization apply data minimization	51
decision authority clarify decision authority	15
decision rationale document the decision rationale	51
deliverable specify the deliverable	14
dependency flag a dependency	15
desirable criterion distinguish desirable criteria	5
effective accommodation assess an effective accommodation	50

Find a term and its context

The page number leads to the definition and a typical word combination. Repeated terms have separate entries when they serve different lesson contexts.

employee assistance program	explain the employee assistance program	69
employee relations	manage employee-relations concerns	32
employee response	record the employee response	23
escalation route	identify the escalation route	15
escalation trigger	define an escalation trigger	60
essential criterion	define essential criteria	5
essential function	identify essential functions	50
evidence preservation	arrange evidence preservation	33
facilitated discussion	arrange a facilitated discussion	59
factual record	maintain a factual record	24
false equivalence	avoid false equivalence	60
feedback conversation	hold a feedback conversation	23
feedback loop	create a feedback loop	15
finding	distinguish a finding from an allegation	33
first-month plan	agree a first-month plan	14
firsthand account	distinguish a firsthand account	32
follow-up evidence	review follow-up evidence	24
formal warning	distinguish a formal warning	24
functional limitation	clarify a functional limitation	50
ground rule	establish ground rules	59
halo effect	check for the halo effect	6
handoff	define the handoff	60
handoff criterion	agree handoff criteria	60
headcount	state the headcount basis	68

Find a term and its context

The page number leads to the definition and a typical word combination. Repeated terms have separate entries when they serve different lesson contexts.

impact statement make an impact statement	23
impartiality maintain impartiality	33
implementation date confirm the implementation date	51
improvement action confirm the improvement action	24
independent ownership confirm independent ownership	15
individual notification arrange individual notification	68
individualized assessment conduct an individualized assessment	50
informal coaching provide informal coaching	24
intake conduct an intake conversation	32
interactive process engage in the interactive process	50
interim arrangement confirm an interim arrangement	50
interim measure explain an interim measure	33
internal equity review internal equity	41
interview panel brief the interview panel	5
job evaluation conduct a job evaluation	41
job level verify the job level	41
job requisition open a job requisition	5
job-related competency assess job-related competencies	5
leading question avoid leading questions	33
line manager confirm the line manager	15
manager briefing prepare a manager briefing	69
market adjustment assess a market adjustment	42
market benchmark review the market benchmark	41
measurable objective agree a measurable objective	23

Find a term and its context

The page number leads to the definition and a typical word combination. Repeated terms have separate entries when they serve different lesson contexts.

mediation assess whether mediation is appropriate	59
medical confidentiality preserve medical confidentiality	51
merit increase review a merit increase	42
message cascade coordinate the message cascade	69
midpoint calculate the midpoint	41
milestone set a learning milestone	14
modified schedule assess a modified schedule	50
need-to-know basis share on a need-to-know basis	33
neutral question ask a neutral question	32
notice period confirm the notice period	69
observable behavior describe observable behavior	23
offer approval obtain offer approval	6
onboarding plan the onboarding	14
onboarding completion qualify onboarding completion	15
open question record open questions	69
operating model review the operating model	68
orientation attend orientation	14
paraphrase offer a neutral paraphrase	59
pay compression examine pay compression	42
pay disparity investigate a pay disparity	42
pay grade confirm the pay grade	41
pay transparency explain pay transparency	42
performance expectation clarify performance expectations	23
performance gap identify a performance gap	23

Find a term and its context

The page number leads to the definition and a typical word combination. Repeated terms have separate entries when they serve different lesson contexts.

performance improvement plan	review the performance improvement plan	24
performance standard	apply the performance standard	23
policy exception	document a policy exception	51
policy owner	consult the policy owner	51
position	distinguish a position	59
position elimination	distinguish position elimination	68
preboarding	coordinate preboarding	14
promotion increase	distinguish a promotion increase	42
ramp-up period	support the ramp-up period	14
range maximum	identify the range maximum	41
range minimum	identify the range minimum	41
range penetration	calculate range penetration	41
rating anchor	define rating anchors	5
readiness review	conduct a readiness review	15
reasonable adjustment	discuss a reasonable adjustment	6
recency bias	avoid recency bias	23
redeployment	explore redeployment	68
reframing	use constructive reframing	59
reported account	attribute a reported account	32
request status	communicate request status	51
respondent	hear the respondent's account	32
responsibility matrix	update the responsibility matrix	60
restricted access	maintain restricted access	51
restructuring	communicate a restructuring proposal	68

Find a term and its context

The page number leads to the definition and a typical word combination. Repeated terms have separate entries when they serve different lesson contexts.

retaliation concern raise a retaliation concern	33
retention risk assess retention risk	69
review checkpoint set a review checkpoint	51
review date set a review date	24
review meeting schedule a review meeting	60
review route explain the review route	51
review scope define the review scope	68
right of response provide a right of response	24
role ambiguity reduce role ambiguity	59
role clarity establish role clarity	14
role impact assess role impact	68
role profile clarify the role profile	5
rumor address a rumor accurately	69
salary range publish a salary range	41
scope of inquiry define the scope of inquiry	33
scoring rubric apply the scoring rubric	5
screening call arrange a screening call	6
selection criteria explain selection criteria	68
selection rationale document the selection rationale	6
severance explain severance terms	69
shadowing arrange job shadowing	14
shortlist develop a shortlist	6
sign-off obtain manager sign-off	15
situational question use a situational question	5

Find a term and its context

The page number leads to the definition and a typical word combination. Repeated terms have separate entries when they serve different lesson contexts.

specific example	give a specific example	23
stakeholder map	review the stakeholder map	15
structured interview	conduct a structured interview	5
substantiated	explain a substantiated finding	33
success criterion	agree success criteria	14
supervised practice	schedule supervised practice	14
support commitment	record the support commitment	24
supporting documentation	handle supporting documentation	51
talking points	approve talking points	69
target bonus	explain the target bonus	42
task ownership	clarify task ownership	59
time to fill	state the time-to-fill basis	6
total cash compensation	define total cash compensation	42
total rewards	describe total rewards	42
transition support	provide transition support	69
trial period	set a trial period	60
underlying interest	identify underlying interests	59
undue hardship	assess undue hardship	51
variable pay	distinguish variable pay	42
witness	identify a possible witness	32
work adjustment	discuss a work adjustment	50
work sample	evaluate a work sample	6
working agreement	record a working agreement	60
workplace barrier	identify a workplace barrier	50

Original cases. Clear boundaries.

These are original fictional teaching conversations, not transcripts of real workers. Names, figures, organizations, and incidents are invented. Sources support terminology and communication aims, not the fictional results or an endorsement of this book.

[1] US Office of Personnel Management. Structured Interviews.

[Open the original source](#)

Background on job-related competencies, consistent questions, and common rating standards. The selection exercise and candidates are fictional. Checked 10 October 2026.

[2] US Equal Employment Opportunity Commission. Prohibited Employment Policies/Practices.

[Open the original source](#)

US background on discrimination and retaliation. This book does not determine whether any fictional or real act meets a legal test. Checked 10 October 2026.

[3] US Equal Employment Opportunity Commission. Disability Discrimination and Reasonable Accommodation: Medical Inquiries, Leave and Telework.

[Open the original source](#)

US background on individualized accommodation discussions and information handling. No request in this book is legally adjudicated. Checked 10 October 2026.

[4] Acas. Carrying Out an Investigation.

[Open the original source](#)

UK background on fair fact gathering and objective evidence review. Local procedures and rights must be checked separately. Checked 10 October 2026.

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